The Dependency Trap: Domestic Violence and Claim-making in India

Job Market Paper

*

Surili Sheth[†]

October 12, 2026

Abstract

Comparative politics research finds that legal reform and expanded policing have had limited effects on women's reporting of domestic violence. Building on feminist political theory, I argue claimants face a *dependency trap*: seeking redress from institutions that reproduce the unequal relationships on which their survival depends. This creates a tension between protection and agency. I distinguish patriarchal institutions, whose authority or procedures stabilize marriage, from intermediaries whose legitimacy does not depend on preserving it. In an ethnographically motivated vignette experiment with 2,034 ever-married women in Gujarat, respondents expect all institutions to reduce violence, but expect women's organizations to support *separation* more than patriarchal institutions. Exploratory text analysis and case trajectories from an archive of 564 domestic violence cases suggest a mechanism: navigational capacity across state and societal domains. Institutional demand under dependency reflects not only protection from harm, but whether intervention preserves or expands agency over dependent relationships.

Keywords: Comparative Politics; Legal Mobilization; Claim-Making; Intermediaries; Gender-Based Violence; Institutional Demand; Access to Justice; South Asia

*I thank Hansaben, Jashiben, Pradeep Chhibber, Cecilia Mo, Livia Schubiger, Soledad Prillaman, Thad Dunning, Jennifer Bussell, Rachel Brulé, Soledad Prillaman, Ishana Ratan, Vaishnavi Surendra, and Bhumi Purohit for their comments on this work. Mahashweta Jani, Aarthi Muthukumar, Shobhit Kumar Prabhakar, Ilesh Dharek, Manoj Modi, Khushi Hinduja, and Kruti Shah were an excellent research team. I am grateful to the members of the EMPESA Oslo conference, EGEN Stanford and Bergen conferences, ETH Zürich IRDS workshop, UC Berkeley CPD workshop and Center on Contemporary India for opportunities to workshop this project. This project has been generously supported by the Foreign Language Area Studies (FLAS) Dissertation Fellowship, the Dissertation Research Grant from the Center on Contemporary India, and the Pre-Dissertation Research Grant from the Institute for International Studies at UC Berkeley. The research is covered under IRB e-protocol number 2022-12-15913. The survey experiment analysis was pre-registered on the OSF Registry. AI was used to refine my code, writing, and formatting.

[†]Postdoctoral Fellow, ETH Zürich; surili.sheth@gess.ethz.ch.

1 Introduction

When harm occurs inside a relationship on which a claimant depends, what makes an institution one she is willing to approach? Domestic violence offers a stark case of this problem. In contexts where marriage organizes women's access to economic security, social status, housing, and kinship support, institutions that nominally protect women from violence may also enforce marital stability and family preservation (Manne 2017; Lake and Hartman 2025; Kruks-Wisner, Mangla, and Sukhtankar 2025; Roychowdhury 2021*a*). Seeking redress therefore raises a problem that precedes institutional responsiveness: claimants must consider not only whether an institution can address the harm, but what institutional intervention will do to the relationships on which they continue to depend.

A large scholarship on institutional responsiveness shows that representation, legal reform, and bureaucratic interventions can increase the likelihood that marginalized citizens' claims are registered and acted upon (Chattopadhyay and Duflo 2004; Pande 2003; Bobo and Gilliam 1990; Beaman et al. 2009; Lowande, Ritchie, and Lauterbach 2019). Within policing and justice institutions, women officers and gender-targeted reforms can change how officials respond to gendered claims (Sukhtankar, Kruks-Wisner, and Mangla 2022; Kruks-Wisner, Mangla, and Sukhtankar 2025; Meier and Nicholson-Crotty 2006; Jassal 2020; Cheema et al. 2026). Yet evidence that these reforms increase reporting itself remains mixed (Blair and Jassal 2022; Amaral, Bhalotra, and Prakash 2021; Iyer et al. 2012; Lazarev 2019). In India, fewer than one percent of women who report physical or sexual violence by their husbands report it to the police, and formal reporting rates have remained extremely low despite decades of legal and institutional reform (Sharma and Gupta 2024). This gap raises an antecedent question: even when potential claimants expect institutions to respond to violence, why do they expect some institutions, but not others, to support the outcomes they seek?

Building on feminist political theory, I argue that potential claimants face a *dependency trap*: they seek redress from institutions that reproduce the unequal relationships on which their survival depends. When the relationship producing harm also structures access to housing, livelihood, social standing, care, or kinship support, institutional intervention affects two distinct dimensions of welfare. It can provide *protection* by reducing the immediate harm, but it can also expand or constrain a claimant's *agency* over the relationship producing it. These goals need not move together. An institution may successfully discipline a perpetrator or broker a reduction in violence while simultaneously stabilizing the dependent relationship and narrowing the claimant's ability to alter it.

The dependency trap describes a situation where institutions themselves reproduce dependency. I thu distinguish *patriarchal institutions*, whose authority or procedures stabilize the dependency – in this case, the patriarchal bargain upheld in marriage (Kandiyoti 1988), from autonomous *intermediaries*, whose organizational legitimacy does not depend on preserving this core dependency structure. This distinction cuts across the conventional divide between state and non-state institutions. Caste organizations govern marriage through kinship and community authority; women police wield formal legal authority. However, both operate within institutional structures that treat marital preservation as a valued endpoint of intervention. They sustain dependency in different ways, but both operate in the shadow of the same dependency trap: the patriarchal bargain embedded in endogamous marriage.[1] Women's organizations provide a contrasting institutional form: as intermediaries, they are embedded in state and community relationships without deriving their legitimacy from keeping a woman in her marriage.[2] By locating institutions according to their position in preserving the dependency, I derive empirical expectations: patriarchal institutions will provide episodic protection while reproducing dependency; women's organizations, however, are perceived as providing protection without making preservation of the dependent relationship a condition of that protection.

This institutional difference generates distinct expectations for survivors of domestic violence making an institutional claim to *stay* or *leave* the violent marriage. When a woman seeks to reduce violence while remaining in her marriage, patriarchal institutions can intervene without fundamentally challenging the relationship through which dependency is organized. Caste authorities can pressure or counsel family members; police can threaten or apply state sanctions. Supporting separation, however, requires recognizing an outcome that alters the relationship whose preservation these institutions help enforce. This distinction matters on this margin: women's organizations are more strongly associated with support for separation, while remaining just as capable, in respondents' expectations, of supporting pressure and compromise within marriage. The distinction is therefore not that patriarchal institutions help women stay while intermediaries help women leave. It is that protection through patriarchal institutions remains embedded in the preservation of the dependent relationship, while women's organizations expand the range of relational outcomes perceived as available.

[1] Importantly, these institutions are interested in preserving a specific type of marriage: endogamous, monogamous marriage. See (Sabnis 2025) for a description of how this type of relationship is ideologically and practically upheld by Indian judicial institutions.

[2] I use *patriarchal institution* to refer to institutional position and operating procedures rather than to the gender of the people staffing the institution. Women police can therefore operate within a patriarchal institutional structure.

I develop this argument through fifteen months of ethnographic fieldwork in rural Gujarat and test its implications using a vignette experiment embedded in an in-person survey of a representative sample of 2,034 ever-married women across 45 villages and a block headquarters town. The experiment varies the institution that a hypothetical survivor approaches for help and measures respondents' expectations about two kinds of outcomes: whether violence will decrease, and what happens to the marital relationship. I examine whether institutions are expected to support separation, to pressure a husband and his family to stop the violence, or to facilitate compromise. The design therefore distinguishes expected protection from expected support for changing the dependent relationship itself. I complement the experiment with three waves of India's nationally representative National Family Health Survey, a micro-survey, analysis of caste organization constitutions, and an original archive of 564 domestic violence case files compiled through my ethnographic fieldwork.

I find two main results. First, respondents expect engagement with any institution to reduce violence substantially more than a status quo in which no institution is approached. Low institutional demand therefore cannot be explained simply by a belief that institutions are incapable of providing protection from violence. Second, respondents expect women's organizations to support separation from a violent marriage more than patriarchal institutions. However, I do not find that women's organizations are perceived as less capable of supporting ways to stay[3] compared to patriarchal institutions. Rather than revealing a simple tradeoff in which one class of institutions provides protection and another provides agency, the results show that women's organizations expand the set of outcomes perceived as institutionally available: they support violence mitigation without making preservation of marriage a necessary tradeoff.

Finally, I explore whether and how women's organizations differ from patriarchal institutions, even when each class of institution is expected to support staying in marriage. Text-as-data analysis of open-ended survey responses show that respondents who say that each type of institution will help pressure the husband to stop the violence, thus enabling a survivor to stay in a violent marriage, describe caste organizations primarily in terms of persuasion and counseling and women police more often in terms of concrete state action. However, women's organizations are the only institution associated strongly with *both* of these repertoires of support. Trajectories from actual domestic violence cases similarly show women's organization counselors moving across police, courts, family negotiations, maintenance

[3]In this context, the most popular institutional interventions that support staying in marriage include pressuring a violent husband to stop being violent or facilitating compromise within the marriage.

claims, residential arrangements, and community relationships. I call this mechanism *navigational capacity*: the ability to traverse across public and private spheres in helping claimants reorganize the relationships on which they depend.[4] This combination of evidence identifies it as a mechanism through which intermediaries can combine intervening to mitigate violence with intervening to help women exercise greater agency by renegotiating the obligations of dependent relationships – whether within or outside of marriage.

These findings make two contributions. First, I extend scholarship on institutional responsiveness, legal mobilization, and claim-making by showing that expected responsiveness to harm is only one component of institutional demand (Corbridge et al. 2005; Kruks-Wisner 2018; Holland 2015; Jassal 2020; Sukhtankar, Kruks-Wisner, and Mangla 2022; Albiston, Edelman, and Milligan 2014). When claims arise within relationships of dependence, potential claimants also evaluate what institutional action will do to the relationships and resources through which they survive. The dependency trap therefore adds a relational dimension to explanations centered on efficacy, bias, mistrust, norms, and individual endowments.

Second, I contribute to scholarship on gender and institutions by identifying the *institutional reproduction of dependency* as a dimension along which apparently different institutions may be theoretically similar. Caste organizations and police lie on opposite sides of the conventional state–society divide (Acemoglu et al. 2020; Winters and Conroy-Krutz 2021), but both reproduce the patriarchal bargain by stabilizing marriage. This perspective helps explain why reforms that increase the capacity or representativeness of a bureaucracy may improve its responsiveness to women who report while still leaving the protection–agency tension intact (Htun and Weldon 2018; Waylen 2014; Roychowdhury 2021*a*; Prillaman 2023). Women's organizations matter not only because they are more responsive to intimate partner violence, but also because their institutional position makes citizens expect them to intervene to protect without necessarily requiring preservation of the relationship producing it.

The dependency trap is not specific to domestic violence, women, or India. It arises where a

[4]Women who acquire political influence often exercise it precisely by moving across these boundaries. For example, Brulé's (2020*b*) elected women *sarpanches* helped women citizens form integrative bargains with their family members to bargain property inheritance in exchange for dowry right before marriage; Mangla's (2022) government-mobilized, women local field-workers challenged village patriarchy and exclusion and forged programmatic ties with lower caste women; outside India, Nazneen's (2023) women political intermediaries in Mozambique, Nigeria, and Pakistan navigated across state authorities, community organizations, and kinship networks to address problems ranging from access to public services to family disputes and domestic violence.

relationship is simultaneously a source of harm and a conduit to resources or status on which a claimant depends, and where political institutions capable of addressing the harm are themselves implicated in stabilizing that relationship. For example, migrant domestic workers under kafala-type sponsorship systems who face violence from their employers may depend on employers for wages, housing, and legal status in ways that are structured and stabilized by state-enforced contracts (AlShehabi 2021; Blaydes 2023; Parreñas 2022). Graduate students harmed within supervisory relationships may similarly risk funding, credentials, references, and professional belonging when making claims within the same institution that provides these professional networks and resources (Lake and Hartman 2025; Srinivasan 2021; Behl 2020). These dependent relationships differ substantively from marriage, but share a power structure: protection from harm may require intervention in a relationship that also supplies valued resources, and institutions tasked with intervening stake their reputation, legitimacy, or resources on stabilizing the existing dependency relationship. Understanding institutional demand therefore requires asking not only whether institutions can respond, but also whether their responses preserve or expand agency over the relationships on which claimants depend.

2 Theory

2.1 The Dependency Trap and Marriage

I argue that claimants can face a *dependency trap*: they seek redress from institutions that reproduce the unequal relationships on which their survival depends. The trap arises when the relationship that produces harm also organizes access to resources and social standing, while institutions capable of addressing that harm are implicated in stabilizing the relationship itself. In such settings, institutional demand depends not only on whether an institution is expected to respond to a claim, but also on what institutional intervention will do to the relationships and resources on which the claimant continues to depend.

The distinction between "public" and "private" spheres has long structured scholarship on gender and political economy, with the state associated with formal rights and markets, and the household with kinship, care, and informal authority (Pateman 1988; Agarwal 1997; Kabeer 1994; Kandiyoti 1988). This literature shows that the private sphere is not outside politics, but a central site of gendered power.[5] However, for women seeking to leave violent marriages, the challenge is not simply

[5]See applications of this in the growing bodies of gender and politics work measuring women's preferences (Lindsey 2023; Khan 2017), gatekeeping and backlash (Cheema et al. 2023; Brulé 2020*a*; 2023; You 2025), social norms (Gibson and Gouws 2026; Cheema et al. 2026), welfare regimes (Iversen and Rosenbluth 2006), and institutional reproduction

about interventions that cross the boundary from public to private. Instead, authority over marriage is fragmented across multiple institutional domains. State institutions govern legal entitlements such as maintenance and protection. Kinship and caste institutions regulate the social legitimacy and costs of separation. Across these domains, women are recognized primarily through their marital status, and no single institution can provide the full set of conditions required for exit.

In Gujarat, as across much of South Asia, marriage is not only an intimate relationship but an institutional arrangement through which women access housing, livelihood, social legitimacy, and kinship support (Kandiyoti 1988; Chhibber 2002; Deshpande 2024).[6] Women's legal and social identities are reorganized around the marital household at marriage: the widespread practice of village exogamy means women marry into families distant from their natal home (62% of the married women surveyed in this study live in a joint family in their marital households), daughters have been historically constructed as the wealth of another man's lineage upon marriage,[7] and access to property, social standing, and kinship support is routed through the husband's family (Brulé 2020*b*; Agarwal 1997).

Both economic and social dependence compound this reorganization. In terms of economic agency, nearly three-quarters of women in the study area (72%) lack an active personal bank account and 61% have no say in whether to take a loan, consistent with patterns documented across rural India in which married women's access to productive assets and financial instruments is mediated through the marital household (Agarwal 1997). Social mobility is mediated through the marital family: 67% of the sample reports needing permission to travel by bus or train, 65% need permission to meet their own family and friends, 64% need permission to go to the doctor.[8] Overall, violence within marriage threatens survival across multiple registers simultaneously. Departure from the marital household risks the loss of housing, income, access to children, and social legitimacy at once. Long-term exit from a violent marriage is thus not simply difficult; it is costly in ways that threaten the basic conditions of survival.

(Lake and Hartman 2025).

[6] This is why intimate partner violence is studied as domestic violence in this context. Its intimate structure extends to family and kinship, and violence is not only committed by the intimate partner.

[7] Majumdar (2009) traces the historical emergence of the "marriage market" (matrimonial advertisements, the consolidation of dowry as a central transaction) to the colonial era, arguing that arranged marriage and the intergenerational family were reshaped and performed as traditional, and not actually inherited as unchanged customs. The construction of daughters as transactable wealth can thus be traced back to a historical formation instead of a cultural given.

[8] See Appendix A3.

2.2 Protection, Agency, and the Institutional Reproduction of Dependency

The dependency trap creates a tension between two dimensions of institutional intervention: *protection* from harm and *agency* over the relationship producing it. These dimensions are often implicitly treated as opposites. Safety is associated with reducing violence while preserving an existing relationship, whereas agency is associated with exit from it. Yet feminist theories of agency and bargaining suggest that this is a false dichotomy.

For Kabeer (1999), empowerment concerns the expansion of people's ability to make consequential choices under conditions in which that capacity was previously denied. Agency is therefore not reducible to a single observable outcome such as exit; it includes decision-making, bargaining, negotiation, resistance, and the ability to define and pursue one's own objectives. The concept of the patriarchal bargain similarly emphasizes that women exercise agency within social relationships whose terms they did not freely choose (Kandiyoti 1988). Bargaining approaches locate women's choices within the resources, fallback positions, norms, and institutions that structure their negotiating power both inside and outside the household (Agarwal 1997; Brulé 2020*b*).

A substantial violence-against-women literature correspondingly emphasizes the importance of women's economic resources and assets (Agarwal and Panda 2007; Panda and Agarwal 2005; Aizer 2010; Bloch and Rao 2002), of cash and in-kind transfers (Bobonis, González-Brenes, and Castro 2013; Hidrobo, Peterman, and Heise 2016), and of social and health service provision (García-Moreno et al. 2015; Feder et al. 2011). The concept of dependency shifts the idea from being merely about service provision to being about the role that institutions play in survivors' navigation of relationships. If exit is not a supported option (Calvi and Keskar 2026; Adam-Rahman 2026),[9] then resources that appear to strengthen an outside option may still fail to make exit viable in practice.

Agency therefore cannot be inferred simply from whether a woman stays in or leaves a marriage. A woman may remain while renegotiating its terms; conversely, formal exit may provide little meaningful choice if it destroys access to the resources on which survival depends. Protection and agency can likewise come apart. An institution may punish a perpetrator, broker a reduction in violence, or compel compromise while simultaneously stabilizing the dependent relationship and limiting the claimant's ability to alter it. The relevant question is whether intervention permits the claimant to exercise agency

[9] Adam-Rahman (2026) puts this succinctly in the case of married women's realistic exit options, even when they earn income: "Because divorce carries a strong social stigma, women's income does not provide a credible exit option and thus leaves household power relations largely unchanged." For example, in the study setting of this paper, income that was earned by married women was often, in practice, given to, and controlled by, mother-in-laws.

over *how* the dependent relationship is reorganized—including the possibility of a safer relationship within marriage as well as separation from it.

This problem is visible where reforms formally expand women's rights without changing the relationships through which those rights must be exercised. Reforms granting women formal entitlements without altering this structure can generate backlash (Brulé 2020*b*; Kulkarni 2017; Pierotti, Lake, and Lewis 2018; Mansbridge and Shames 2008), and in the starkest situations, worse outcomes: inheritance reform in India is associated with increased female suicide and mortality where women gained rights they could not safely exercise (Anderson and Genicot 2015; Rosenblum 2015; Roy 2015).[10] The same institutional embeddedness conditions what registers as harm in the first place, since condonation of gender-based violence rises both with patriarchal values and with contextual features that let the violence be construed as ordinary to the relationship (Gibson and Gouws 2026).

The dependency trap therefore directs attention to the institutions through which bargaining takes place. When people face the dependency trap, institutional demand depends not only on potential claimants' expectations of responsiveness to harm, but on whether institutions can make the socially aberrant desire to exit survivable for her. It is insufficient for an institution to offer services to reduce violence by punishing perpetrators in the short term. Institutions must also address the relational consequences of claim-making if they are to support a claimant in exercising agency over the relationship. In the case of domestic violence, what happens to a claimant's housing, livelihood, social support, and access to children if she pursues exit from a violent marriage?

I distinguish *patriarchal institutions*, whose authority or procedures stabilize the patriarchal bargain of marriage, from *intermediaries*, whose organizational legitimacy does not depend on preserving it. This distinction is not equivalent to state versus non-state, formal versus informal, or strong versus weak institutions. Rather, it captures an institution's position relative to the reproduction of dependency. Patriarchal institutions can provide protection while reproducing dependency; intermediaries can provide protection without making preservation of the dependent relationship a necessary condition of that protection.

Institutions also differ in the repertoires through which they intervene. The dependency trap argu-

[10] Brulé (2020*b*) shows the mechanism directly. Extending daughters' inheritance rights generated backlash against women who gained rights without bargaining leverage; for those already married, eligibility combined with access to female local representatives *reduced* the likelihood of inheriting land. The reform left intact the expectation that a daughter's property transfers to her in-laws, making the claim costly within the relationships she already depended on (Agarwal 1994).

ment identifies two features that shape how institutional actors can support claim-making: *relational authority* and *legal literacy*. Relational authority is standing sufficient to intervene in the relationships that constitute a claimant's dependency. Legal literacy is knowledge of statutory remedies and the practical access required to activate them. These capacities are conceptually distinct from an institution's position relative to dependency: either can be deployed to stabilize a relationship or to help reorganize it. Autonomy from the dependency structure—defined as organizational legitimacy independent of the patriarchal bargains of marriage—is what allows these capacities to be used for *reorganization* of dependent relationships instead of simply restoring them for stability.[11]

2.2.1 Patriarchal Institutions: Protection through Marital Stability

Patriarchal institutions can possess substantial capacity to intervene in violence while using that capacity within institutional structures oriented toward stabilizing marriage. Caste organizations and women police are important because they possess different repertoires of intervention and sit on opposite sides of the conventional state–society divide. Caste organizations possess substantial relational authority; women police possess formal legal literacy and coercive state capacity. Yet both derive or exercise those capacities within structures that prioritize marital preservation. Their common theoretical position is therefore not that they intervene through the same mechanisms, but that protection is delivered within a dependency-reproducing institutional order.

Relational authority and caste councils. The first feature is *relational authority*: standing that is sufficient to intervene in the relationships that constitute a claimant's dependency. An actor with relational authority can convene the parties who govern a survivor's household and community such as her husband, in-laws, natal family, and caste elders. The survivor can expect its intervention to carry weight in her relationships with these members.

The source of this standing determines the way in which it is used. Much of the authority over marriage, other relational institutions, and local property or assets is held by non-state institutions that adjudicate in their own right, alongside and often in preference to state forums (Lust 2022; Lund 2006; Baldwin 2016; Murtazashvili 2016; Wilfahrt and Letsa 2023; Winters and Conroy-Krutz 2021). In the Indian case, these bodies are composed of local patriarchal elites and exercise that authority

[11]The idea of *relational capacity* is also emergent in a burgeoning state capacity literature (Honig, Krishnamurthy, and Sharma 2025) and in the women's bargaining power literature (Brulé 2020*b*).

substantially over the marriages of the communities they govern (Kumar 2012; Chowdhry 2004; 2007). Their embeddedness shapes their interpretive logic: institutions deriving authority from stabilizing a dependency relationship read harm as a disruption to a relationship worth preserving, and pursue outcomes that restore it (Htun and Weldon 2018; Waylen 2014).

In rural India, caste councils[12] derive authority from community standing and the ability to impose social sanctions (Galanter 1963; 1981; Solanki 2011; Kumar 2012). They work through negotiation, counseling, and compromise rather than formal adjudication, producing bond-paper agreements that regulate behavior without legal enforceability. Such agreements are instances of the broader pattern in which durable relationships like kinship structures and hierarchies within them, not courts, do the work of enforcement (Nagaraj 2010; Macaulay 1963; Ellickson 1991).

However, the relational authority of these organizations is explicitly oriented toward sustaining endogamous marriage. For example, the written constitution of the majority Other Backward Class caste organization in the study region, the *Talpada Patel Samaaj Zamp Chovisi*,[13] opens under the heading "Precautionary Measures Against Divorce," framing dissolution as equivalent to losing everything in life. Resolution 28 routes all dissolution through the caste committee and fixes penalties by marriage type. Resolution 31 permits a husband to take a second wife if the first has not borne children by age 35, requiring only that she receive grain, clothing, and a monthly allowance. Resolutions 29 and 30 make widow and divorcee remarriage conditional on committee approval. A 2018 amendment fines parties Rs. 1,100 each for any divorce and adds Rs. 11,000 for those who "betray the General Committee" by dissolving a marriage privately. This financial architecture is congruous with the marriage transfers that structure the relationship itself, where dowry obligations serve as an instrument of ongoing extraction and violence — not just a one-time payment (Bloch and Rao 2002; Calvi and Keskar 2026).

The parallel constitution of a major Scheduled Caste group in the region, the *Vankar Pargana Gnati Panch*,[14] shows the same orientation from a very different social position. Its divorce provisions

[12]In Gujarati these are often referred to simply as *samaaj* ("community") or *gnaathi*, similar to *jati*, or sub-caste, in other North Indian states. Caste councils in Haryana are called *khap panchayats*, which are better studied in the social sciences literature due to their role in upholding the patriarchal bargains of their communities through extreme and lethal methods such as honor killings (Chowdhry 2007; Bhattacharya 2024).

[13]The Talpada Patel (also known as Koli Patel) caste is a subset of the main cultivator caste forming the largest voter bloc in Gujarat, the Kolis (Shah 2002; Yagnik and Sheth 2005; Daftary 2024). The constitution is printed and distributed door-to-door as a handbook whenever a new elder comes to power; see Appendix A1. Such written caste constitutions became a norm when British colonizers began codifying Hindu laws into a single framework (Yagnik and Sheth 2005).

[14]Both handbooks were gathered by counselors at Bens' Center. New rules are often also published in the local

require the return of dowry if a wife does not remain with her husband, and impose Rs. 25,000 on a wife who leaves with her children, thus penalizing maternal exit with no equivalent for paternal exit.[15] Both constitutions also gatekeep the courts. The *Vankar Gnathi* text is explicit: "No party can go to the Court without obtaining the permission of the Community Council. Any person violating this section will be liable to pay Rs. 1001/- under the community clause." It repeats the requirement under "Functions of the Community Panch,"[16] exempting only suicide, and directs that any crime committed in the village be reported to the council leader and the nearest committee member rather than to the police. The *Talpada Patel* constitution reaches the same result through fines on private dissolution of marriage.

These institutions are therefore not intermediaries to the state: they hold relational authority and actually use it to foreclose legal literacy and engagement with the state. That the pattern recurs across an OBC and a Scheduled Caste organization suggests it is structural rather than the practice of a single community.[17] Caste councils draw legitimacy from the same community structures that enforce women's dependency within marriage, so supporting exit would erode the authority on which they rest (Kumar 2012).

Legal literacy, state action, and women police. The second feature is *legal literacy*: knowledge of statutory remedies and the practical access required to activate them. Formal institutions hold this capacity by definition. However, many derive their own authority from preserving the social order within which dependency relationships rest (Merry 1988; Basu 2015; Subramanian 2014; Sezgin 2013), and their embeddedness in local power leaves them open to capture by the actors who reproduce that dependency (Heinze 2025). Descriptive representation does not resolve this. Large-scale analysis of Indian district courts finds that women judges do not decide claimants' cases differently, indicating that organizational features of the judiciary dominate the identity of individual decision-makers (Ash et al. 2025).

India's legal architecture for domestic violence has expanded substantially since the 1980s. However, its implementation remains oriented toward marital preservation instead of survivor safety. Section 498A of the Indian Penal Code, passed in 1983, criminalized cruelty within marriage, establishing

newspaper, and clippings circulate as WhatsApp screenshots among counselors and community members.

[15] There is some symmetry: a husband who refuses to keep his wife must pay Rs. 25,000 to the wife's father.

[16] Community *panch* is the caste council.

[17] Only 8% of the study sample is Muslim and 6% is from Scheduled Tribes; the remaining 86% follows the Hindu caste system, following the general demographics of this region.

a specific legal remedy for women experiencing domestic abuse (Roychowdhury 2021*a*; Agnes 2011). The Protection of Women from Domestic Violence Act (PWDVA) of 2005 extended civil remedies such as protection orders, residence rights, maintenance, and custody, to a broader range of domestic relationships. It also established a separate bureaucratic apparatus for investigating these claims.[18] Finally, police reforms created women's police stations and help desks as dedicated reporting spaces in many states (Roychowdhury 2021*b*; Jassal 2020; Sukhtankar, Kruks-Wisner, and Mangla 2022).

Despite these nominal expansions in bureaucratic capacity and representation, the institutional architecture within which domestic violence laws operate remains structurally oriented toward reconciliation. A 2009 Ministry of Home Affairs circular instructs state governments that matrimonial disputes should first be routed through conciliation and mediation, with criminal prosecution under 498A reserved for cases where reconciliation fails (Ministry of Home Affairs, Government of India 2009). The circular quotes a Delhi High Court judgment lamenting that "these provisions have resulted into large number of divorce cases as when one member of the family is arrested and sent to jail without any immediate reprieve of bail, the chances of salvaging or surviving the marriage recede into the background and marriage for all practical purposes becomes dead" (Ministry of Home Affairs, Government of India 2009).[19] Alongside of this reconciliation-first policy, the Supreme Court subsequently constrained the immediate coercive force of a Section 498A complaint by directing police not to make an automatic arrest upon registration and requiring written justification for arrest, subject to magistrate review (Supreme Court of India 2014; Agnes 2017). The bureaucracy created to implement

[18]The statutory provisions discussed here are those in force during the period covered by the case file archive. India recodified its general criminal law with effect from 1 July 2024: the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, 2023 (BNS) replaced the Indian Penal Code, the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023 (BNSS) replaced the Code of Criminal Procedure, and the Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam, 2023 replaced the Indian Evidence Act. Section 498A IPC now corresponds to Section 85 BNS, with the definition of cruelty—previously an explanation appended to 498A—separately codified at Section 86; the offence, its ingredients, and its punishment carry over substantially unchanged. Section 125 CrPC, governing maintenance, now corresponds to Section 144 BNSS, likewise with the substantive provision retained. Proceedings initiated before 1 July 2024 continue under the repealed provisions. The PWDVA, as a special statute, was not repealed and remains in force. Its procedural cross-references to the CrPC are now read as references to the corresponding BNSS provisions. Because the recodification preserved the substance of both provisions and postdates the case files analyzed here, it does not bear on the empirical claims; I retain the older section numbers throughout, which also remained in colloquial and professional usage for the duration of my fieldwork.

[19]In a case decided on January 8, 2026 alleging domestic violence by a husband and his family, the Karnataka High Court used the same reasoning to quash the case, holding that allegations spanning physical violence during pregnancy and economic and emotional violence "reflect the daily wear and tear of marriage and can, in no way, be categorised as cruelty [...] The said situation is a mirror reflection of the Indian society where men of the households often try to dominate and take charge of the finances of the women but criminal litigation cannot become a gateway or a tool to settle scores and pursue personal vendettas." The judgment also emphasizes the episodic nature of qualifying violence, implying that ongoing harm within marriage is insufficient: "The term 'cruelty' cannot be established without specific instances" (Karnataka High Court 2026).

the PWDVA has itself been thinly staffed. National monitoring found Protection Officer posts routinely left vacant or assigned as additional charge to officers with unrelated primary duties (Lawyers Collective Women's Rights Initiative 2012); in Gujarat, a single full-time Protection Officer has been documented carrying some 800 cases while simultaneously expected to appear in court, conduct home visits, and serve documentation (Jha 2016; Roychowdhury 2021*b*). The result is a legal system that nominally protects women from violence while structurally prioritizing preservation of the marriages within which that violence occurs.[20]

Because most marital disputes settle outside court, such a legal landscape shapes outcomes well beyond the specific cases that the judiciary rules on. What a woman can extract in private negotiation depends on what she could credibly expect from a forum committed to reconciliation (Mnookin and Kornhauser 1979). In India, reconciliation-oriented police and judiciary devalue the legal threat itself, and with it, the bargaining endowment that legal literacy might otherwise supply (Agarwal 1997).

Women's police stations and gender-targeted help desks, when staffed by female officers, increase registration of crimes against women and shift officer behavior toward women's claims (Jassal 2020; Sukhtankar, Kruks-Wisner, and Mangla 2022; Kruks-Wisner, Mangla, and Sukhtankar 2025). But all-women police stations do not significantly increase women's reporting of violence (Jassal 2020), and broader evaluations of gender-targeted policing reforms find mixed effects on gendered crime reporting (Blair and Jassal 2022; Amaral, Bhalotra, and Prakash 2021). Within the system, women's cases face systematic disadvantage: complaints are more likely to be delayed and dismissed at both police station and courthouse, and suspects in women's cases are significantly less likely to be convicted (Jassal 2024). Investigative and evidence-gathering procedures can further work against survivors' claims (Govindrajan 2025). Police thus have the formal capacity to apply coercive pressure through criminal law, but their embeddedness in a reconciliation-oriented architecture constrains their ability to support reorganizing the patriarchal bargain, and particularly to support exiting it, even in cases of violence.[21]

In sum, caste councils hold relational authority but derive it from within the dependency trap. Women police hold legal literacy but operate inside an architecture built to preserve marriage. For both,

[20] This is a tension Newbigin (2013) traces to the colonial constitution of Hindu family law as a site of state governance rather than individual rights.

[21] In practice, regardless of whether a station has a dedicated women's desk, a woman police officer is almost always brought in as first point of contact for domestic violence complaints, making women police the relevant first contact for such complaints at police stations.

successful intervention can mean reducing violence while keeping the relationship intact. Their different repertoires therefore lead to the same theoretical classification: both are patriarchal institutions because their authority or procedures reproduce the dependency relationship even when they provide protection from harm.

2.2.2 Intermediaries: Autonomy from Patriarchal Reproduction

This institutional landscape leaves a gap for a third type of actor: intermediaries whose organizational legitimacy does not depend on preservation of the dependency relationship. Autonomy here does not mean detachment from state or societal institutions. Rather, it means that an organization's legitimacy is independent of the patriarchal bargain of marriage, allowing it to work across the institutions that govern dependency without making marital preservation a necessary endpoint of intervention.

Dependency in marriage is governed across fragmented domains such as legal claims, kinship authority, residential arrangements, and social legitimacy. The dependency trap predicts that institutions equipped for only one domain may relieve particular, often episodic, harms while leaving the relational conditions that produce them intact. Relational authority and legal literacy should therefore operate as distinct capacities in claimants' assessments of who will help. A key question is whether an intermediary can combine them on behalf of a claimant who seeks to exit or renegotiate her dependent relationships. This creates demand not merely for general help, but for intermediaries who can traverse both state and societal institutions (Kruks-Wisner 2022; Auerbach and Thachil 2018; Gottlieb, LeBas, and Magat 2025; Kruks-Wisner 2018; Roychowdhury 2019).[22]

Women's organizations. In rural India, women's organizations are often expected to serve as such intermediaries. They have historically operated at the interface of community and state, not drawing their authority entirely from either, but navigating both (Prillaman 2024; Bhanjdeo et al. 2025). Their strength varies as a function of their relationship to the state and to external funding. Organizations embedded within state institutional structures have proven vulnerable to withdrawal of support when their activism challenges patriarchal or caste authority, while those achieving structural autonomy from both donor priorities and state definitions of acceptable activism show greater capacity to address structural matters (Chakravarti 2008; Jandhyala 2001; Htun and Weldon 2018; Bhatt 2005*a*).

[22] This is distinct from political brokerage, whose leverage runs through party machines and the selective distribution of goods (Auyero 2001; Stokes et al. 2013; Kitschelt and Wilkinson 2007; Krishna 2002).

Sponsorship is not inherently disqualifying to this autonomy. Instead, what matters is whether its terms insulate an organization from pressure to redirect its work away from structural claims. A large evaluation literature treats women's groups as an effective delivery platform (Díaz-Martín et al. 2023), but this instrumental framing does not answer the political question of what these groups are mobilized for. Other evaluations point to state sponsorship at scale channeling women's organizations toward financial discipline and service delivery (Kalpana 2017; Devika and Thampi 2007).[23] The strongest such organizations derive authority from collective organization instead of proximity to state or elite authority, while also preserving their access and legibility to the state (Sanyal 2014; Prillaman 2024).[24]

Through savings groups, health campaigns, and dispute intervention, their embeddedness in community life gives them reach across the caste, kinship, and legal domains that together constitute authority over the dependency relationship. In her anthropological study of women's counseling and domestic violence in India, Kowalski (2023) asks, "how can people organize interdependence in terms that are mutually sustaining, rather than coercive or exploitative?" Women who seek counseling are not looking to be free of dependent ties, but to reorganize dependence.

The institutional distinction is therefore not that patriarchal institutions support staying whereas women's organizations support leaving. Patriarchal institutions can provide protection, but do so within institutional structures that reproduce the dependent relationship. Women's organizations, as intermediaries, are autonomous from the requirement to preserve marriage and can therefore support protection without predetermining whether the claimant stays or leaves. Their community embeddedness may supply relational authority, while their interaction with police, courts, and legal services may supply legal literacy. Whether they are in fact perceived as combining these repertoires is an empirical question that I examine after the main experiment. I refer to the ability to work across these fragmented state and societal domains on behalf of a claimant as *navigational capacity*.

[23] An intensive pilot phase of state-sponsored self-help groups in Bihar generated substantial gains in women's empowerment and collective agency under intensive local facilitation. Under the lighter touch of the state-wide scale-up, these effects largely did not replicate, even as credit and debt-relief functions persisted (Datta 2015; Hoffmann et al. 2021).

[24] As Cruz and Tolentino (2019) show in the rural Philippines, political influence is itself gendered. Men gain influence through formal political activity -such as holding office, party membership, and connections to powerful officials. On the other hand, women's influence derives from community embeddedness and from being known as someone who can help others navigate institutions and access services. Collective organizational membership and community volunteering predict women's political influence more strongly than any formal political credential. Leaders of women's organizations that build authority through collective action are therefore not substituting an informal pathway for a formal one, but operating in the register through which women's authority is recognized in the first place.

2.3 Empirical Implications: Protection, Leaving, and Staying

The dependency trap generates different empirical expectations depending on what a claimant asks an institution to do. The first concerns *protection*: institutions may be broadly perceived as capable of reducing overt violence even when they differ in whether their interventions preserve or reorganize the relationship producing it. The second concerns the relational outcome of intervention. It is here—in expectations about staying versus leaving—that the empirical traces of the dependency trap should become visible.

The argument therefore distinguishes institutional effectiveness from institutional function. Service delivery reforms operate through channels where institutions derive authority from meeting claimants' needs; improving representation can shift whose needs get prioritized (Chattopadhyay and Duflo 2004; Pande 2003). Justice delivery, by contrast, operates through institutions whose authority is partly derived from stabilizing the social order within which harm occurs. This is the same order that structures the relationships claimants depend on for survival (Jassal 2024; Weaver and Lerman 2010). This distinction helps explain why responsiveness reforms improve outcomes once claims are lodged while producing more limited effects on reporting itself: what claimants seek once inside institutions differs from what they are evaluating when deciding whether to enter at all.

This pattern is visible in India's formal reporting rates. Despite expanding formal remedies under 498A and the PWDVA, women's rates of formal reporting remain below one percent (Sharma and Gupta 2024), while disclosure rates to informal sources are substantially higher (Palermo, Bleck, and Peterman 2014). Qualitative evidence consistently shows that women approach formal institutions as a last resort after other options have failed (Roychowdhury 2021*a*; Agnes 2017). This is not because they necessarily doubt that institutions can reduce violence, but because formal legal engagement under 498A risks collapsing the very arrangement within which survival is embedded (Supreme Court of India 2014; Agnes 2017). Because even marriage-preserving institutions are expected to check violence, the observable implication is that any institutional engagement should be expected to reduce violence relative to the status quo, regardless of whether it reorganizes the underlying dependency relationship.

The relational implications become clearer when distinguishing *staying* from *leaving*. The theory characterizes institutions not as pure substitutes for one another,[25] but rather as functionally differen-

[25]This follows from sociolegal scholarship which points out that dispute resolution processes are nonlinear processes, where grievances move between formal legal and informal or nonlegal, often societal, processes, not linear processes

tiated in potential claimants' eyes by their structural position relative to the dependency relationship. Caste organizations derive authority from marriage preservation and are oriented toward outcomes that keep the marital relationship intact. State institutions operate under an administrative and judicial architecture that explicitly prioritizes conciliation and reconciliation. Both should therefore be expected to deliver staying-related outcomes: coercive pressure and negotiated compromise. Women's organizations, by contrast, are not expected to be subject to the same institutional constraint. Out of the available institutions, then, they should be distinctively expected to support renegotiations around the central institution of dependency—marriage—including exit.

What exit looks like in practice, and why it takes the form it does, is illustrated by the following case from the Bens' Center archive:

> Hetalben[26] has been married for twelve years and has two children. She reports sustained physical and verbal abuse by her husband and his family, economic deprivation, and threats intended to deter her from approaching the police — her husband threatens to throw acid on her brother. After a counseling session at the women's organization, she decides she would like to live separately in her natal home with shared custody of her children. Rather than filing a domestic violence case, she pursues a maintenance claim under Section 125 of the Code of Criminal Procedure (CrPC), which would secure monthly financial support and allow her to live in a separate residence while remaining a married woman in her caste community, care for her aging parents, and see her children without facing violence.
>
> — *Case 2015-40*

Hetalben's case illustrates the architecture of separation that married women commonly seek: not formal divorce, but a livable arrangement that preserves social standing, secures material survival, and removes the immediate threat of harm (Mahoney 1991; Suneetha and Nagaraj 2006).[27] Maintenance claims under Section 125, negotiated bond-paper agreements,[28] and temporary or permanent residence in natal homes are among the more common pathways through which *de facto* longer-term separation is

that move up a single formal legal pyramid or else attrit (Albiston, Edelman, and Milligan 2014).

[26] Pseudonym to protect respondent confidentiality.

[27] Mahoney (1991) argues that in the United States, legal categories are organized around separation as a discrete, completed act, rendering the partial and negotiated arrangements women construct invisible as responses to violence; Suneetha and Nagaraj (2006) discuss the same gap in India, documenting the myriad ways in which women seek to negotiate their relationships and exert agency through different forms of managed separation from, or renegotiation of the terms of, marriage.

[28] Bond paper agreements are written contracts signed by both parties, often with witnesses or a local mediator present, recording mutually acknowledged commitments regarding maintenance, custody, or separation arrangements. In

achieved without formal dissolution. Dommaraju (2016) documents that separation rates substantially exceed divorce rates in India, consistent with qualitative evidence that women navigate exit through informal and semi-formal arrangements instead of through formal legal dissolution. It is this form of exit, rather than divorce, that constitutes a common objective among women who seek to leave violent marriages after multiple counseling sessions and often after negotiation with the marital family has failed.

Figure 1 summarizes the empirical implications. Both patriarchal institutions and intermediaries are expected to reduce violence relative to the status quo. The dependency trap should become visible in the relational outcomes respondents associate with each institutional type: patriarchal institutions are expected to have a relative advantage on staying-related outcomes, while intermediaries are expected to have a relative advantage on leaving-related outcomes. The H2 columns represent predicted relative advantages rather than exclusive institutional capacities: women's organizations may also support pressure or compromise, and patriarchal institutions may sometimes support separation.

	INSTITUTIONAL REPERTOIRES				
	RELATIONAL AUTHORITY	LEGAL LITERACY	VIOLENCE REDUCTION (H1)	LEAVING OUTCOMES (H2A)	STAYING OUTCOMES (H2B–H2C)
Patriarchal institutions: authority or procedures stabilize marriage					
Caste organizations	✓	✗	✓	—	✓
Women police	✗	✓	✓	—	✓
Intermediaries: legitimacy does not depend on preserving marriage					
Women's organizations	✓	✓	✓	✓	—

Figure 1: **Institutional repertoires and expected outcomes under the dependency trap.** ✓ indicates that a repertoire or outcome is more expected; ✗ indicates that a repertoire is less expected; — indicates that the theory does not predict a *relative advantage* on that outcome. Both patriarchal institutions and intermediaries are expected to reduce violence (H1). Intermediaries are expected to have a relative advantage on leaving-related outcomes, namely separation (H2A), whereas patriarchal institutions are expected to have a relative advantage on staying-related outcomes, including pressure and compromise (H2B–H2C).

practice, such agreements vary: some are executed on government-issued stamp paper of a designated denomination (e.g., Rs. 100 or Rs. 500), which carries evidentiary weight under the Indian Stamp Act, 1899, while others are drafted on plain paper with no formal legal standing. Neither constitutes a court-registered document or judicial decree, and neither carries the full enforceability of a court order, though stamp paper agreements may be produced as evidence in subsequent proceedings. When plain agreements are signed at a women's organization and the counselors are called in to testify using these agreements, they can also become evidence in court. The counselors are always careful about what details they record in writing because their records or testimony may be used in evidence (Ramaswamy et al. 2023; Govindrajan 2025).

This pattern of differentiated institutional specializations distinguishes the argument from a simple institutional quality account under which one institution would be expected to outperform across all justice delivery outcomes. Whether or not the institution specializes in what an actual survivor wants depends on her evolving situation and desires. H1 tests whether the relevant institutions are perceived as capable of protection at all. H2 identifies where the empirical traces of the dependency trap should appear: in respondents' expectations about which institutions will support different forms of help that either preserve or alter the dependent relationship. In this sense, institutional position relative to the reproduction of dependency—rather than formal status, state affiliation, or institutional strength—is the theoretically relevant dimension of institutional demand.

> **H1. Protection from Violence**: Married women will expect engagement with any institution—patriarchal institutions or intermediaries—to reduce violence more than staying in the status quo.
>
> **H2A. Leaving**: Married women will expect intermediaries (women's organizations) to support a survivor's **separation** from violent marriages at higher rates than patriarchal institutions (caste organizations and women police).
>
> **H2B and H2C. Staying**: Married women will expect patriarchal institutions (caste organizations and women police) to apply coercive **pressure** on the husband to stop the violence at higher rates than intermediaries (women's organizations). The same expectation holds for facilitating a **compromise**.

3 Context: Marriage and Domestic Violence Claims in India

Indian women consistently face some of the highest levels of intimate partner violence (IPV) in the world. The country has a lifetime domestic violence prevalence rate between 33–41%, and fewer than one percent of women who experience physical or sexual violence by a husband report to the police (Dandona et al. 2022; Sharma and Gupta 2024). Furthermore, the suicide death rate among women in India was reported to be twice the global rate, with housewives accounting for the majority of suicide deaths. The reasons for these are documented as "personal/social" (Dandona et al. 2022). The prevalence of lifetime IPV is markedly higher for ever-married women in rural India (31.0%–40.2%) compared to their urban counterparts (24.4%–30.4%) (Figure A.1).

Using pooled analysis from three waves of the state- and nationally representative National Family Health Survey in India (2005-06, 2015-16, and 2019-21), which implements a domestic violence module in a random sample of surveyed, ever-married women, I find that among survivors of IPV, current marital status is the individual characteristic most strongly associated with her claim-making portfolio. Divorced or separated women are 23.3 percentage points less likely to remain silent than currently married women — that is, they are more likely to have told someone or sought help from some source. This is comparable in magnitude to the association with injury from the violence (21.9 points), and roughly twice that of experiencing multiple types of violence (12.2 points). Other widely studied individual characteristics are associated with much smaller differences in self-reported silence: currently working (3.3 points), justifying wife beating (1.3 points, in the opposite direction), and secondary education or higher (1.1 points, not distinguishable from zero at conventional levels) (Figure A.2). The dependency structure of marriage is thus highly correlated with women's silence in the face of violence.

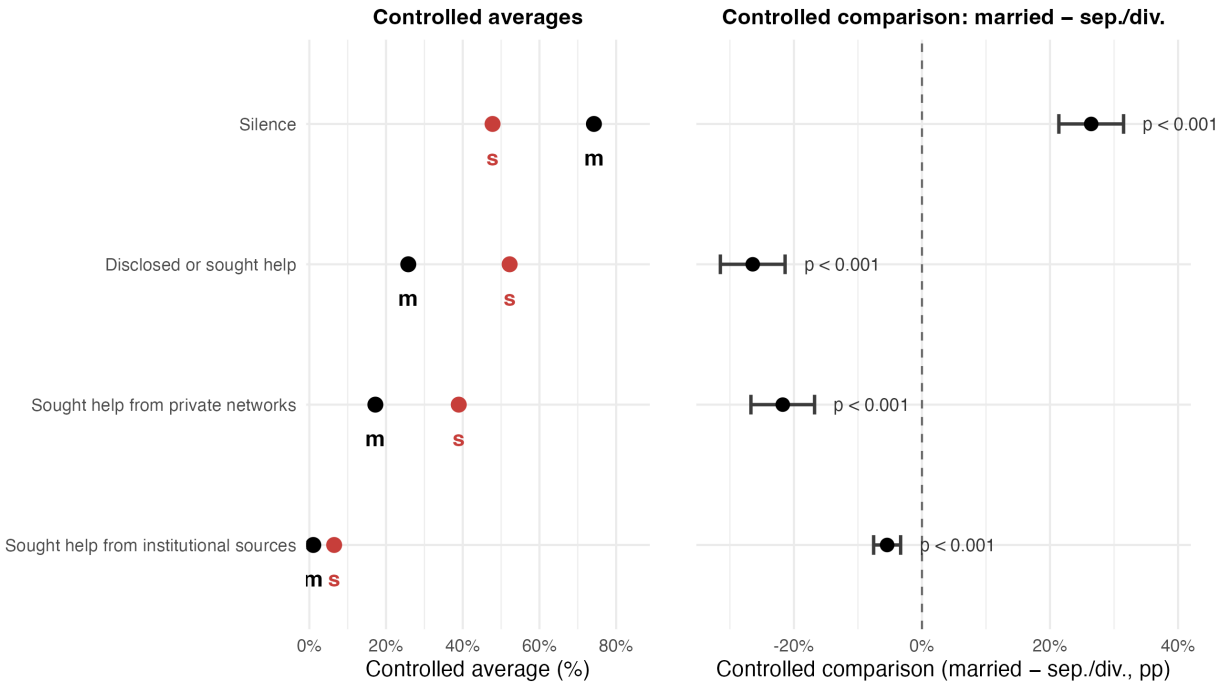


Figure 2: Claim-making among currently married and separated or divorced IPV survivors, All India

Note: Observational. Survey-weighted linear probability models among ever-married women ages 15–49 in NFHS-3, NFHS-4, and NFHS-5 who completed the domestic-violence module and reported spousal physical and/or sexual violence. The left panel shows model-adjusted shares for currently married (m) and separated/divorced (s) women, averaged over the observed covariate distribution; the right panel shows the difference between them, which equals the marital-status coefficient because the models are linear and unsaturated. Horizontal lines are 95% confidence intervals. Models control for number of violence types, wife-beating justification, work status, age, children ever born, years since marriage, caste, education, wealth, wave fixed effects, and rural residence. Silence = told no one and sought no help; disclosed or sought help = either; private networks = family, husband's family, partner, friends, or neighbours; institutional sources = religious leader, social service organization, medical personnel, police, or lawyer. Categories overlap except for silence. Unweighted N: 55,489 currently married; 1,941 separated/divorced.

Controlled comparisons sharpen this pattern. Currently married survivors are 26.4 pp more likely to report remaining silent than already separated or divorced survivors — 74.2% against 47.8% — and correspondingly less likely to have disclosed or sought help from any source. That gap is carried overwhelmingly by private networks, where married women are 21.8 pp less likely to have turned to family, friends, or neighbors (17.2% against 39.0%). Institutional help-seeking differs by only 5.5 pp, though this is a more than sixfold difference off a very low base: 1.0% of married survivors against 6.5% of separated or divorced ones (Figure 2). These claim-making trends are similar when looking at

restricted samples of both rural India, where the typical ever-married Indian woman lives,[29] and rural Gujarat (Figure A.4). Importantly, Gujarat falls roughly at the center of the distribution of Indian states in terms of proportion of IPV survivors who report remaining silent (Figure A.5).

4 Research Design

I test the institutional expectations of married women through a vignette experiment embedded in a survey in rural Gujarat. In this setup, respondents are given the same scenario about a hypothetical domestic violence survivor in their community which randomizes one of three institutions the survivor turns to for help (treatment groups), or gives no further information (status quo group). Within each treatment condition, the scenario also randomizes whether the survivor approaches the institution alone or with a natal family member. Respondents are then asked about their expectations about the kind of support that the survivor would receive for two different types of outcomes: effectiveness (violence mitigation), and outcomes related to the marriage (separation, pressuring the husband to stop, and compromise).

Constructing the experiment required both an ethical protocol for interviewing married women privately about a sensitive topic and a design with sufficient construct and ecological validity (Lake and Hartman 2025; Thachil 2018). I therefore developed the vignette through fifteen months of sustained pre-survey ethnographic fieldwork between 2022 and 2024, drawing on ethnographically motivated survey design (Auerbach and Thachil 2018) and on the use of survey experiments—including vignettes and conjoint designs—to examine how features of gender-based violence situations shape attitudes, beliefs, and judgments (Gibson and Gouws 2026; Schwarz, Baum, and Cohen 2022). The fieldwork centered on a grassroots women's organization in the rural *taluka* in which the survey was administered, which I call the Bens' Center (BC).[30]

I shadowed BC's domestic-violence counselors during counseling sessions and accompanied counselors and claimants to police stations and courthouses, often alongside marital or natal family members and caste elders. I also observed the organization's savings, loans, and welfare-entitlement work and community events surrounding marriage, including caste-organized group weddings. I collected caste-organization constitutions, announcements of changes to caste rules, marriage materials, and

[29] Nearly seven in ten Indian women, and ever-married Indian women ages 18–49, live in rural areas (Office of the Registrar General & Census Commissioner, India 2011; International Institute for Population Sciences (IIPS) and ICF 2021).

[30] Both the specific region of rural Ahmedabad district and the organization are obscured to preserve privacy. *Ben*, or "sister," is a respectful and familiar form of address for women in Gujarat.

the legal and counseling materials used by BC. I wrote fieldnotes during or immediately following observation (Emerson, Fretz, and Shaw 2011). Finally, I organized and digitized 564 handwritten domestic-violence case files from 2000–2023. With a local GBV researcher, I translated the detailed files from 2012–2023 ($n = 345$) and followed up with the counselors who had handled those cases to clarify missing institutional and relational context.

This fieldwork performed three functions in the research design. First, it identified the institutional choice as a substantively meaningful margin: women's claims moved among caste organizations, women's organizations, police, courts, and family actors rather than along a single formal pathway. This observation motivated the comparison between patriarchal institutions and the women's-organization intermediary. Second, observation and case files informed the content and language of the vignette, including the survivor's age and marital history, the embedding of partner violence within broader familial violence, and the vernacular used to describe abuse. Third, survivors' concerns informed the outcomes: whether intervention would reduce violence, support separation, pressure the husband and his family to stop the violence, or facilitate compromise. The experiment thus operationalizes the theoretical distinction between expected protection and expected support for staying or leaving while retaining the ecological features of domestic-violence claim-making observed during fieldwork.

4.1 Survey sampling

The survey was administered face-to-face by trained female enumerators in Gujarati between August 12 and September 11, 2024 in a rural *taluka* of Gujarat.[31] It was administered to 2,034[32] ever-married women[33] between the age of 18 and 50,[34] across 45 villages and 1 block headquarters town. I first constructed a census for the survey sample by using machine-learning methods with Gujarati voter rolls in all of the polling booths (n=128) of the *taluka* in which the Bens' Center operates.[35] I then randomly selected 16 women per polling booth, and created an original sample list, and three replacement sample lists for each polling booth. We refined this sample based on the women's organization counselors' knowledge about whether women on the list were present or not, and they made phone calls to

[31]The *taluka* is not named to further protect respondent identities. Full sampling details are provided in Appendix A10.
[32]The survey was carried out for 2,034 out of 2,048 sampled respondents.
[33]95% of the sample was currently married.
[34]This was the age range within which 97% of complainants of case files from over 20 years at the women's organization fell.
[35]The voter rolls contain information about the gender, age, and indications of the marital status of women citizens, and had been recently updated for upcoming elections.

community contacts to verify the lists. Women from the replacement lists were selected to be on the original list if sampled respondents on the original list were not locatable. The same protocol was followed if a sampled respondent could not be found on the survey day or the buffer day for the polling booth.

I recruited and trained a team of 25 surveyors who worked in teams of 5, with one field manager per 2 or 3 teams per day, and me and a research associate supervising; each supervisor and their teams covered a walkable area of polling booths in one day, and each surveyor completed 4-5 surveys per day, each survey lasting an average of 35 minutes each.[36] The survey was conducted from morning to early evening, to balance access to women who were at home and those who were out working in the fields. An IRB-approved, explicit protocol about explaining the content of the survey to family members, to gain access to the married woman respondent to ask her consent to participate, was followed, and surveyors were trained through both role-play and two rounds of piloting.[37]

4.2 Vignette

The vignette experiment presented the following scenario to all respondents.

> *Suppose Gauriben is a 28-year-old woman from your area. She has been married for 6 years. Her marriage was done as per the customs of the society. Initially, everything went well after the marriage, but for the last few years, her husband has been mentally and physically abusing and torturing her. Her in-laws have also been nagging her about her household chores, inciting her husband to misbehave with her.*

The vignette is grounded in the case profiles from BC's archive. The majority of respondents in the case files from 2001 to 2023 are between 18 and 50 years old (Figure A.22), with an average age of 28. The vignette thus uses this age and describes a woman married for six years, implying marriage at age 22, to reflect a typical case.[38] Finally, specifying that her marriage was as per the customs of society implies that it is a same-caste, arranged marriage and therefore one that should be stable and upheld.

[36] See Appendix A6 for information about attrition and manipulation checks.

[37] See Appendix A10 for more details on sampling and survey protocols and Appendix A13 for details on design and ethical considerations.

[38] More extreme cases would include child marriages with earlier age at marriage, or complaints lodged at much older years of age where abuse was more prolonged. Though not infrequent, these scenarios may be considered more "extreme" and lead to over-estimates in supporting behavior by institutions. By keeping the scenario more "typical," I expect to get more under-estimates of institutional support.

The description of violence also reflects common reporting practices in the case file archive. Complaints are frequently summarized as "physical and mental abuse by the husband," a formulation used to encompass a wide range of physical, sexual, and emotional harms. This phrasing is retained in the vignette to evoke a realistic, generalizable experience of violence without specifying an extreme or atypical scenario. Finally, most cases in the archive involve not only the husband but also in-laws as co-participants in abuse, often as instigators. This is incorporated into the vignette design to depict a realistic scenario where domestic violence is embedded in the local marital context. The terms "misbehave" and "inciting" are often specifically used by survivors to describe a pattern of both direct abuse from other marital family members, and indirect participation through the husband, for example, to exert pressure to extract money from the woman's natal family or coerce her into doing more work for the marital household. Taken together, these design choices establish T-validity: the vignette reflects the modal features of documented cases in the study context Rudolph (2025).[39]

4.3 Randomization

Respondents were randomly assigned to one of seven conditions and either saw no additional sentence (status quo condition), or a last sentence of the vignette which varied institution approached, and whether or not Gauriben is accompanied by a natal family member (Figure 3).[40]

> *Gauriben [goes alone / goes with a natal family member] to [her caste organization / a women's organization / women police] for help.*

The institutional variation allows us to test the implications of dependency theory.

Status Quo
T0 **1/4**

		Institution		
		Caste Organization	Women's Organization	Women Police
Credibility	Alone	T1 **1/8**	T3 **1/8**	T5 **1/8**
	With Natal Family Member	T2 **1/8**	T4 **1/8**	T6 **1/8**

Figure 3. Research Design and assignment probabilities.

[39] This approach to external validity also follows Whiting and Ma (2021), who validate vignette designs against real-world data on land disputes in rural China.

[40] The natal family co-presence variation captures whether a survivor has natal family support when approaching institutions. This variation tests a different theory. Corresponding hypotheses and findings are presented in Appendix A14. All comparisons reported in the paper pool together the "alone" and "with natal family member" groups.

4.3.1 Outcome Variables

Four outcome variables were measured.[41] One captures violence reduction expectations (asked for all conditions) and three measure expectations about whether institutions will help the survivor leave (separate) or stay (compromise or pressure) in the violent marriage (asked for groups t1–t6).

- **Violence reduction**: Do you think that with [institution]'s help / [status quo: in a situation like this] the violence will increase, decrease, or there will be no change?
- **Separate**: Do you think that [institution] would help Gauriben live separately from her husband and in-laws?
- **Pressure**: Do you think that [institution] would intervene and pressure Gauriben's husband and in-laws to stop hitting her?
- **Compromise**: Do you think that [institution] would help Gauriben put forward conditions to negotiate a compromise with her husband and in-laws?

Assignment to treatment conditions was randomized at the individual level, and standard errors were clustered by polling booth.

4.3.2 Estimation

Each hypothesis is tested with a single regression specification,

$$Y_{ib} = \beta_0 + \beta_1 D_{ib} + \gamma' X_{ib} + \tau_b + \epsilon_{ib},$$

where Y_{ib} is the outcome for respondent i in polling booth b, D_{ib} is the treatment contrast of interest, X_{ib} is a vector of pre-treatment covariates, τ_b are booth fixed effects, and standard errors are clustered at the booth level. The estimand is β_1 in each case; the outcome, treatment contrast, and pooled arms vary by hypothesis:

[41] See Appendix A4 for full outcome questions and coding.

	Outcome Y	Treated arms ($D = 1$)	Comparison ($D = 0$)
H1	Violence reduction	t_1–t_6 (any institution)	t_0 (status quo)
H2A	Separation	t_3, t_4 (women's organization)	t_1, t_2, t_5, t_6 (patriarchal institutions)
H2B	Pressure	t_3, t_4 (women's organization)	t_1, t_2, t_5, t_6 (patriarchal institutions)
H2C	Compromise	t_3, t_4 (women's organization)	t_1, t_2, t_5, t_6 (patriarchal institutions)

For each contrast I report three specifications: (1) the unadjusted treatment regression with booth fixed effects ($\gamma = 0$, booth fixed effects only); (2) the covariate-adjusted model above, which is my preferred specification; and (3) post-double lasso (PDL) with machine-learning-selected controls (Belloni, Chernozhukov, and Hansen 2014). Each is reported for both the full analytical sample and the sub-sample passing the relevant manipulation checks (MC pass).[42] Balance tables and randomization checks are in Appendix A5.

5 Results

5.1 Expected Protection from Violence

H1: Violence Reduction. Seeking help from any institution changes community expectations about violence outcomes. Figure 4 presents means and average treatment effects (ATEs) comparing any institutional assignment to the status quo condition.

[42] For H1 and H2, the MC pass sample is restricted to respondents who correctly identified the institution in their assigned condition.

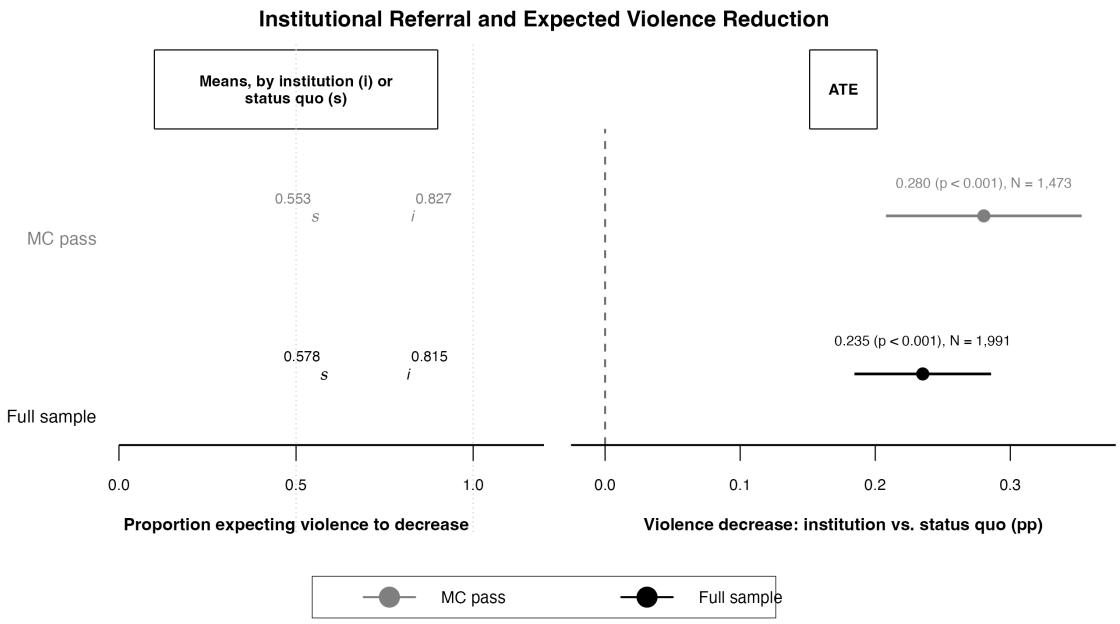


Figure 4: Reporting to Any Institution Expected to Mitigate Violence More Than Staying in the Status Quo. *Note*: Left panel shows proportions expecting violence to decrease for any institution (i) and status quo (s) conditions. Right panel shows ATEs with 95% confidence intervals. The figure reports covariate-adjusted OLS results for the full sample (black) and the sub-sample that passed the manipulation check (gray). Standard errors clustered at the polling booth level. The unadjusted and post-double lasso estimates are shown in Appendix A8. Regression tables in Appendix A9.

The ATE of any institutional assignment relative to the status quo is 23.5 percentage points ($p < 0.001$) in the full sample and 28.2 percentage points ($p < 0.001$) in the MC Pass subsample, consistent across all three estimation strategies. In the status quo condition, where Gauriben takes no institutional action, 57.9% of respondents expect violence to decrease. Institutional engagement of any kind raises this to 81.6%, a large and robust effect.

The baseline of "loyalty" itself is noteworthy. Nearly three in five respondents believe violence will decrease even without institutional engagement, reflecting the perceived efficacy of non-institutional, informal mechanisms that would be used in the status quo such as family pressure, social disapproval, or the husband's eventual behavioral change.[43] This baseline is also consistent with the general norm of endurance that I observe among respondents: when asked, "do women in a situation of being hit usually endure or seek help?" 59% of respondents said that they endure.[44]

[43]This is consistent with legal sociological studies which qualitatively document women's behavior within the dependency trap. For example, legal scholars Suneetha and Nagaraj (2006) describe in their historical overview of how domestic violence has evolved as a public issue in India that "central to women's negotiations seems to be the "project of reforming the husband" making him into a considerate and responsible being. This project, for them, is crucial to keeping the marriage and family going."

[44]This question was asked in a module before the survey experiment (see Appendix A.9).

However, any institutional engagement treatment raises the proportion of respondents who believe that violence would decrease substantially and significantly, to above four in five. This finding helps diagnose the gap between perceived efficacy of institutions versus any other, more informal sources of help-seeking that would be assumed in the status quo. It means that the question is not whether married women believe that institutions would be responsive to violence if approached about reported physical violence. Married women believe they would, significantly above even their optimistic expectations in the status quo.[45]

5.2 Leaving and Staying

Figure A.16 compares the intermediary treatment—women's organizations—with patriarchal institutions—caste organizations and women police—across separation (H2A), pressure (H2B), and compromise (H2C).

[45]Exploring further, respondents also expect greater violence reduction from women's organizations than from patriarchal institutions. In the full sample, 88.3% of respondents assigned to women's organizations expect violence to decrease, compared with 80.3% assigned to caste organizations or women police; the estimated difference is 7.1–7.4 percentage points across specifications ($p < 0.001$). This comparison was not pre-registered and is reported in Appendix A8. The main result for the theory, however, is that respondents perceive all three institutional types as capable of protection. I next examine whether they differentiate among them when intervention changes the marital relationship itself.

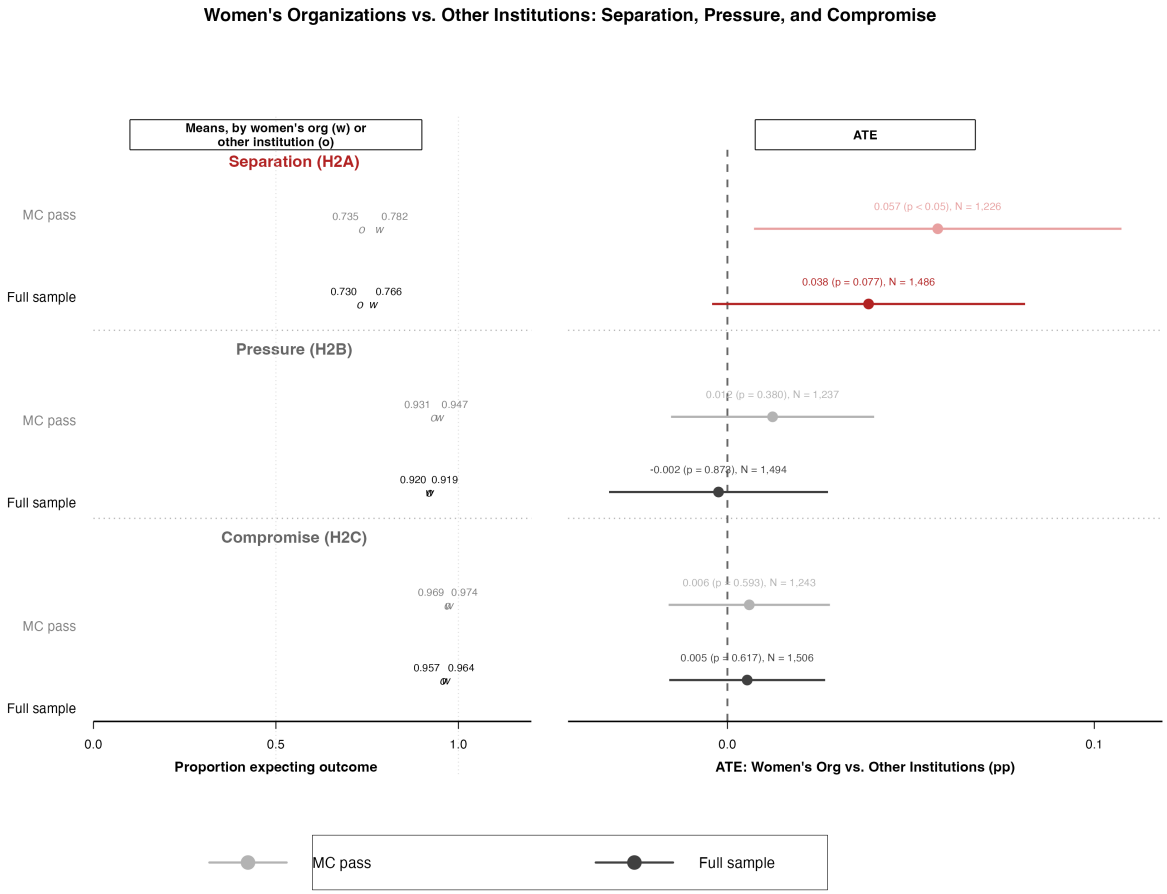


Figure 5: Intermediaries vs. Patriarchal Institutions:Separation, Pressure, and Compromise. *Note*: ATE estimates with 95% confidence intervals. Three model specifications per outcome: simple difference in means, covariate-adjusted OLS, and post-double lasso. Full sample estimates in solid color; MC pass estimates faded. Separation (H2A) in red; Pressure (H2B) and Compromise (H2C) in gray. Clustered standard errors at the polling booth level. Individual outcome figures in Appendix A8; regression tables in Appendix A9.

H2A: Leaving The ATE of women's organization assignment on the separation outcome is positive and consistent in direction across all six specifications, ranging from 3.7 to 5.7 percentage points. It reaches conventional statistical significance ($p < 0.05$) in both the covariate-adjusted and PDL specifications for the MC pass subsample, and approaches significance ($p \leq 0.092$) in the remaining specifications. In the full sample, 72.9% of respondents assigned to other institutions expect those institutions to help Gauriben live separately, compared to 76.6% assigned to women's organizations. The consistency of direction across all six specifications, combined with the precisely estimated nulls for H2B and H2C below, supports the interpretation that this effect reflects a genuine difference in community beliefs about institutional function.

H2B and H2C: Staying. Contrary to H2B and H2C, I do not find that patriarchal institutions have a relative advantage on staying-related outcomes. For pressure on the husband and in-laws (H2B), the ATE of assignment to the women's organization rather than a patriarchal institution ranges from -0.2 to 1.4 percentage points across all six specifications, with p-values uniformly above 0.28. For negotiated compromise (H2C), the ATE ranges from 0.5 to 0.7 percentage points, with p-values uniformly above 0.51. These are precisely estimated nulls: the confidence intervals are tight and exclude differences of the magnitude observed for separation.

The near-ceiling means—91.9% for pressure and 95.6–96.4% for compromise in the full sample—show that all three institutions are perceived as highly capable of supporting ways to remain in marriage. Women's organizations therefore do not exhibit specialization in terms of supporting the outcome. Instead, the results suggest that they expand the set of relational outcomes perceived as available: respondents expect them to support separation more than patriarchal institutions without sacrificing their expected capacity to support pressure or compromise within marriage. However, these ATEs do not establish that the institutions pursue staying-related outcomes in the same *ways*.

6 Exploring Mechanisms

The experimental findings identify a difference in the relational outcomes respondents associate with patriarchal institutions versus the women's organization intermediary, but they do not identify why women's organizations are perceived differently. I turn to exploratory qualitative and text evidence to examine a possible mechanism: *navigational capacity*, or the ability to work across the state and societal institutions through which dependency is organized.

6.1 Navigational Capacity at the Bens' Center

Despite the architecture of married women's lives being organized around structures and reproduce their dependency, the H2 findings show that married women do expect women's organizations, broadly conceived, to perform quantitatively differently on supporting a survivor to leave an abusive marriage if she wants to. They also perform the same for pressure and compromise — i.e. they are also expected to help women who want to reconcile their marriages in different ways. Ethnographic evidence from shadowing the counselors and cases at the Bens' Center sheds some light on the specific functions that the most prominent local women's organization – the Bens' Center – *does* perform when intervening on behalf of married women who are facing violence.

First, when Hansaben and Jashiben, the main domestic violence counselors at BC, were asked their

personal vision and mission around counseling after I had spent many months observing cases with them, they articulated five key goals. These clearly indicated of their vision of supporting women's autonomy through renegotiation or separation from the dependency trap of an abusive marriage:

1. To make sure women do not face violence.
2. To make sure women can survive on the money that they get.
3. To do what the women want.
4. Even in the future, women can fight for themselves, and also take care of themselves.
5. They start with their husbands. [Then] they are [also] able to face their communities and families.[46]

Second, whenever I shadowed the counselors to other venues as they accompanied complainants on their institutional trajectories, I saw the *navigational capacity* of BC at work. One field note, which I wrote what I observed while waiting in the *taluka's* civil courthouse with Hansaben, a counselor, and a survivor, reads:

> Everyone knows Hansaben, she knows everyone. She gets one lawyer to tell us which courtroom the case is in – she makes *ishara* at him (i.e. gives him meaningful looks) from across the open middle area of the courthouse until he comes over. Then he looks it up online and tells us the case hearing is actually upstairs. [...] When we get upstairs, she knows several men [in the hallways]. She asks one of them, who in turn asks an *olkhaan* [someone he knows] who litigates property cases, to pull up the court number for us [online]. In the meanwhile her village's *sarpanch* is also there [in the hallways of the courthouse, and she talks to him as well.] (Field note, October 12, 2023)

The counselors I shadowed operated in this manner in all of the institutional and community spaces that we went to. Male elders, whether local representatives or community elders, often approached to informally tell them about cases they knew about, and they asked about them, too. Another function that the counselors played was that they were often called as the "local women's representative" by the coroner to be witnesses for autopsies performed on suspected cases of feminicide. In these ways,

[46]Field note from BC, October 28, 2023.

Hansaben and Jashiben performed a dual role: being reputed and legitimate actors on behalf of women to patriarchal institutions, while also remaining outside of them. By maintaining complete financial autonomy,[47] BC maintained a presence that was both embedded but also outside of the local patriarchal structures.

6.2 Expected Institutional Repertoires

To assess whether respondents perceive women's organizations more broadly as combining these repertoires, I turn to an open-ended follow-up question. Respondents who said their assigned institution would help pressure Gauriben's husband to stop hitting her (92% of those assigned to an institution arm) were asked: "How? What would they do?" Enumerators typed a short phrase or sentence-long summary of the answer, in English transliteration of Gujarati.[48]

These comparisons are descriptive: inclusion in this analysis is conditioned on a post-treatment response, and the text analysis was not pre-specified.[49] The share of respondents expecting pressure is high and statistically indistinguishable across the three institutions, consistent with the null estimated for H2B, which makes the textual patterns that follow useful as suggestive evidence about how respondents understand each institution's actions — not whether an institution applies pressure, but what that pressure is understood to consist of.

[47] The women apply for short-term grants when possible. When the interest generated by their savings-and-loans group and payments for counseling are insufficient, they take temporary pay cuts or work as volunteers.

[48] These responses were then coded using a dictionary-based content analysis (Grimmer and Stewart 2013), in which a set of keyword patterns is specified for each mechanism of interest and applied to every response. Because the transliteration of Gujarati is not standardized, the patterns match on loose stems rather than exact strings. Second, because a single response can describe several actions at once, the coding is multi-label: a response is not assigned to one category but flagged for each mechanism it mentions. The dictionary was built inductively from a reading of the full response distribution and then frozen. To assess reliability, I hand-coded a blind random sample of the corpus with the machine labels withheld, and separately hand-checked an over-sample of machine-positive responses for the rarer categories. Agreement statistics, the full dictionary, and the coding decisions that followed from validation are reported in Appendix A11.

[49] The text analysis was not pre-specified in the pre-analysis plan and should therefore also be understood as exploratory.

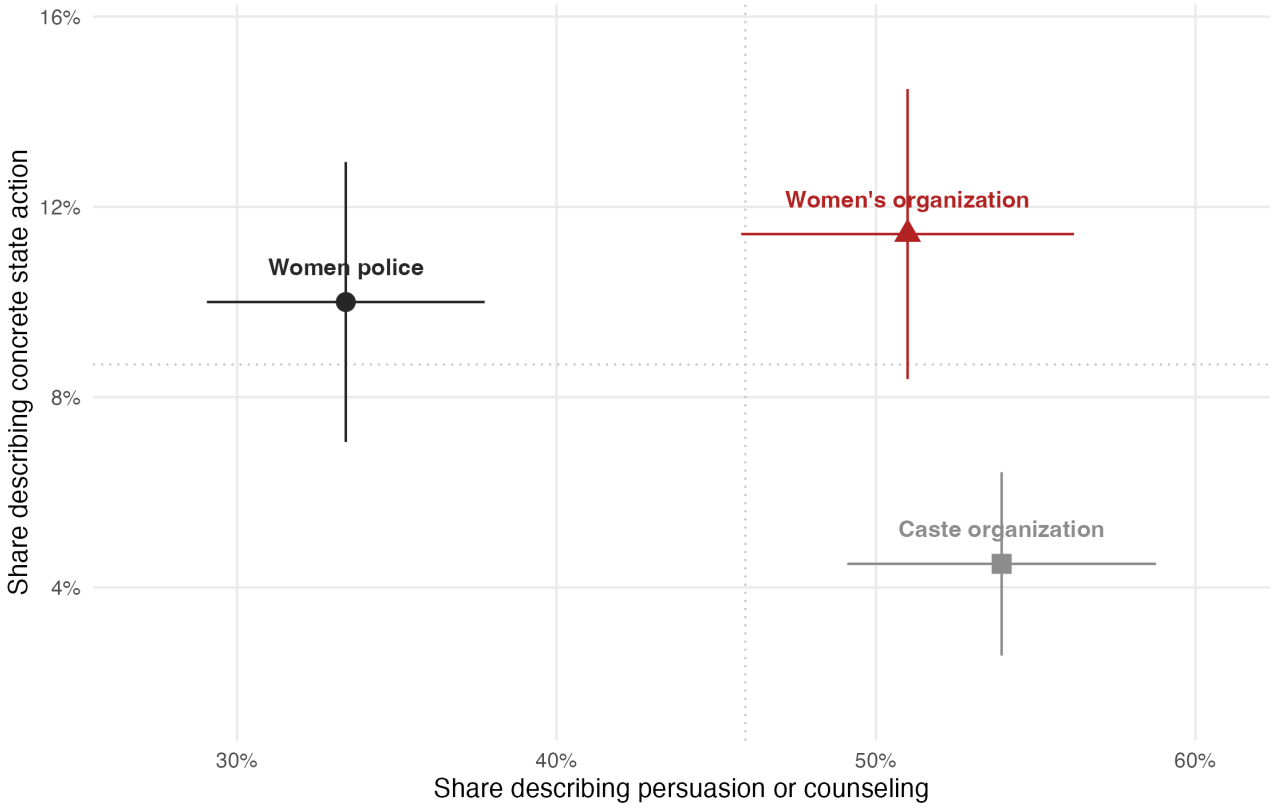


Figure 6: Expected Institutional Repertoires: Persuasion and State Action

Note: Open-ended responses to "How? What would they do?", asked of respondents who expected the assigned institution to pressure the husband and in-laws (arms $t = 1$–6). $N = 455$ (women's organization), 470 (women police), 445 (caste organization); 1,370 total. Ns count non-empty open-ended responses; all but four respondents who expected pressure gave a description (four in the caste-organization arm did not), and both axes are coded on the same responses within each arm. "Persuasion or counselling" denotes making him understand or giving advice (e.g., *samjavse*, will make him understand; *salah aapse*, will give advice; *shikhaman aapse*, will counsel or instruct). "Concrete state action" denotes invoking legal-state machinery (e.g., *kes/fariyad karse*, will file a case; *jel ma nakhi dese*, will put him in jail; *pagla lese*, will take steps/action; court; arrest). Points are institution-arm shares with 95% confidence intervals from booth-clustered standard errors; dotted lines are corpus means. Coding dictionary, hand-validation, and coding decisions are reported in Appendix A11.

Figure 6 locates each institution in the space defined by these two repertoires. Caste organizations are most expected to use persuasion as the mechanism through which pressure will be applied (53.9%; only 4.5% mention state action). A typical response: *"Sudhri jay ana mate salah aapse"* — will give advice so that he improves. Descriptions of how women police are expected to intervene invert this pattern: 10.0% invoke state action — *"Kes thay"* (a case will result), *"Police station lay jay"* (he

will be taken to the police station) — against only 33.4% who describe persuasion, often folded into an individual warning rather than through relational intervention: *"Husband ne samjavse, aavu naa karvu joiye, sari rite revu joiye"* — will make the husband understand, [that] this shouldn't be done, [he] should live properly.

Women's organizations are the only institution above the corpus mean on *both* dimensions (dotted lines, 45.9% and 8.7%), and respondents often describe the two dimensions as sequenced, indicating ongoing involvement, rather than substitutable or one-time action: *"Gouriben na pati ne samjavvani kosish karse. Na samje to kanun ni madad lese"* — will try to make Gauriben's husband understand; if he doesn't understand, will take legal help. The pattern recurs rather than resting on one respondent: *"Samjavase kaydakiy karvahi karse"* — will make him understand, [and] will take legal action. Other responses also directly invoke relational intervention — e.g. *"Samjavse pati, sasu ne ny sanje to kaydesar na pagla lese"* — will counsel the husband and mother-in-law, [and] if they don't agree, will take legal steps.

These patterns provide exploratory evidence for the mechanism suggested by the ethnography. Respondents associate caste organizations primarily with a relational repertoire and women police more often with concrete state action, while women's organizations are the only institution above the corpus mean on both dimensions. The result does not establish navigational capacity causally. Rather, it shows that potential claimants perceive women's organizations as able to combine forms of intervention that are otherwise fragmented across patriarchal institutions. For a claimant whose dependency spans family, community, and state institutions, this combined repertoire may help explain why women's organizations are expected to support a wider range of relational outcomes. Even where women's organizations support survivors who want to stay in a violent marriage, they have a wider repertoire of tools that they can use to help survivors re-negotiate the obligations and benefits within their marriages.

6.3 Discussion

The findings clarify what kind of intermediary is valuable to claimants in a dependency trap. When deciding where to make a claim, the relevant distinction is not simply between state and non-state actors, or between formal and informal institutions. Rather, useful intermediaries combine *autonomy* from the structures that reproduce dependency with *navigational capacity* across the institutional domains through which that dependency is sustained. Their legitimacy does not depend on preserving

the relationship at issue, but they remain sufficiently embedded in the surrounding institutional landscape to negotiate on the claimant's behalf.

This combination brings together two bodies of scholarship. Autonomous feminist organizations, in Htun and Weldon's (2018) account, can challenge established social relations precisely because their organizational survival and authority do not depend on the institutions whose gendered arrangements they contest. Autonomy alone, however, does not make exit possible. Claimants must often coordinate legal remedies with housing, income, kinship obligations, social legitimacy, or other relationships that cross institutional boundaries. Work on relational state capacity similarly treats the relationships through which public authority is exercised as a component of capacity rather than a substitute for it (Honig, Krishnamurthy, and Sharma 2025; Mangla 2022). The relevant institutional position resembles Evans's (1995) "embedded autonomy:" sufficient distance from dominant actors to avoid capture, combined with sufficient embeddedness to coordinate across them. Sociolegal work likewise shows that disputes develop across multiple institutional settings rather than moving linearly through a single legal forum (Albiston 2005; Albiston, Edelman, and Milligan 2014; Basu 2006). Navigational capacity is the ability to support a claimant across those domains.

The two characteristics are therefore complements. An autonomous institution without navigational reach may recognize a claimant's desired outcome but be unable to assemble the conditions that make it viable. An institution with extensive reach but whose authority depends on maintaining the underlying relationship may instead use that capacity to return the claimant to it. In the cases studied here, women's organizations occupy an unusual position between these alternatives. They can draw on legal remedies and police authority while also negotiating with kin, caste actors, and other community institutions. Their role is not simply to connect women to the state, but to combine institutional resources that are otherwise fragmented and deploy them without treating marital preservation as the necessary endpoint (Lake 2018; Roychowdhury 2019; Kowalski 2023).

The comparison also specifies the scope conditions of the dependency trap. First, dependency must be sufficiently bundled that leaving the harmful relationship jeopardizes multiple resources that are costly to replace. Second, institutions capable of addressing the harm must themselves be implicated in governing or stabilizing that relationship. Third, the resources required to make exit viable must be distributed across institutional domains, such that no single authority can reorganize them. The first two conditions generate the dependency trap; the third generates demand for navigational capacity.

These conditions generate comparative predictions. Dependency traps should weaken as resources become more portable, alternative relationships more substitutable, or institutions of redress more independent of the authority sustaining the harmful relationship. Where autonomy exists without navigational reach, claimants may find actors willing to recognize their desired outcome but unable to make it viable. Where navigational reach exists without autonomy, institutional intervention should instead favor restoration of the underlying relationship. Autonomous navigators should be most valuable where dependency is both highly bundled and institutionally fragmented. These predictions provide a framework for comparing institutional demand across otherwise very different relationships of dependency.

7 Conclusion

This paper began with a problem that precedes institutional responsiveness: when harm occurs inside a relationship on which a claimant depends, what makes an institution one she is willing to approach? Evidence from rural India shows that women distinguish sharply between whether an institution can address violence and whether it can help reorganize the relationship in which that violence occurs. Respondents expected caste organizations, women police, and women's organizations alike to reduce violence relative to endurance. Yet women's organizations were distinctively associated with helping a woman separate from a violent marriage, while institutions were not similarly differentiated in their capacity to produce compromise or pressure within marriage. Qualitative evidence suggests that this distinction reflects women's organizations' capacity to combine concrete legal action with negotiation across family and community relationships.

I describe the problem underlying these choices as a *dependency trap*: a condition in which the relationship producing harm also structures access to resources necessary for survival, while institutions of redress are embedded in authority structures that reproduce that relationship. Under these conditions, institutional demand cannot be understood from expected responsiveness to harm alone. Claimants must also anticipate what institutional action will do to the dependencies within which they live. This shifts attention from the capacity of individual institutions to the architecture of the institutional landscape: whether it contains actors with sufficient autonomy from dependency-preserving authorities and sufficient navigational capacity to coordinate the legal and social conditions required to reorganize the relationship.

The argument is therefore broader than domestic violence or rural India. Kafala sponsorship and

graduate supervision illustrate structurally different relationships in which harm can be entangled with access to livelihood, legal status, credentials, or professional belonging. The theory does not imply that these relationships are substantively equivalent. It identifies a common political structure: the relationship producing harm is also part of the infrastructure through which valued resources are obtained, and the institutions capable of addressing harm may themselves be invested in sustaining that relationship. Where these conditions hold, the availability of autonomous navigators should shape whether and where claimants seek redress.

The findings consequently suggest a limit to reforms that conceptualize institutional access primarily as access to enforcement. Increasing the capacity or representativeness of a single state institution may improve what happens once a claimant enters it without resolving the relational costs that make entry difficult in the first place. For people caught in dependency traps, agency may instead depend on access to institutional pathways through which harmful relationships can be renegotiated or left without simultaneously losing the conditions necessary for survival. Understanding institutional demand therefore requires asking not only whether institutions can respond to harm, but what new forms of interdependence their responses make possible to negotiate.

References

Acemoglu, Daron, Ali Cheema, Asim I. Khwaja, and James A. Robinson. 2020. "Trust in State and Nonstate Actors: Evidence from Dispute Resolution in Pakistan." *Journal of Political Economy* 128 (8): 3090–3097.

Adam-Rahman, Natalya. 2026. "The Cost of Women's Work: How Social Norms Limit Women's Political Participation.".

Agarwal, Bina. 1994. *A Field of One's Own: Gender and Land Rights in South Asia*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Agarwal, Bina. 1997. "Bargaining and Gender Relations: Within and Beyond the Household." *Feminist Economics* 3 (1): 1–51.

Agarwal, Bina, and Pradeep Panda. 2007. "Toward Freedom from Domestic Violence: The Neglected Obvious." *Journal of Human Development* 8 (3): 359–388.

Agnes, Flavia. 2011. *Law and Gender Inequality: The Politics of Women's Rights in India*. New Delhi: Oxford University Press.

Agnes, Flavia. 2017. "Are Women Liars? Supreme Court's Judgment Ignores Lived Reality of Married Women." *Economic and Political Weekly Engage* 52 (35).

Aizer, Anna. 2010. "The Gender Wage Gap and Domestic Violence." *American Economic Review* 100 (4): 1847–1859.

Albiston, Catherine R. 2005. "Bargaining in the Shadow of Social Institutions: Competing Discourses and Social Change in Workplace Mobilization of Civil Rights." *Law & Society Review* 39 (1): 11–49.

Albiston, Catherine R., Lauren B. Edelman, and Joy Milligan. 2014. "The Dispute Tree and the Legal Forest." *Annual Review of Law and Social Science* 10 (1): 105–131.

AlShehabi, Omar Hesham. 2021. "Policing Labour in Empire: The Modern Origins of the Kafala Sponsorship System in the Gulf Arab States." *British Journal of Middle Eastern Studies* 48 (2): 291–310.

Amaral, Sofia, Sonia Bhalotra, and Nishith Prakash. 2021. "Gender, Crime, and Punishment: Evidence from Women Police Stations in India." *Journal of Law and Economics* 64 (3): 425–452.

Anderson, Siwan, and Garance Genicot. 2015. "Suicide and Property Rights in India." *Journal of Development Economics* 114: 64–78.

Ash, Elliott, Sam Asher, Aditi Bhowmick, Sandeep Bhupatiraju, Daniel Chen, Tanaya Devi, Christoph Goessmann, Paul Novosad, and Bilal Siddiqi. 2025. "In-Group Bias in the Indian Judiciary: Evidence from 5 Million Criminal Cases." *The Review of Economics and Statistics* .

Auerbach, Adam Michael, and Tariq Thachil. 2018. "How Clients Select Brokers: Competition and Choice in India's Slums." *American Political Science Review* 112 (4): 775–791.

Auyero, Javier. 2001. *Poor People's Politics: Peronist Survival Networks and the Legacy of Evita*. Duke University Press.

Baldwin, Kate. 2016. *The Paradox of Traditional Chiefs in Democratic Africa*. Cambridge Studies in Comparative Politics New York: Cambridge University Press.

Bansak, Kirk, Jens Hainmueller, Daniel J. Hopkins, and Teppei Yamamoto. 2018. "The Number of Choice Tasks and Survey Satisficing in Conjoint Experiments." *Political Analysis* 26 (1): 112–119.

Basu, Srimati. 2006. "Playing off courts: The negotiation of divorce and violence in plural legal settings in Kolkata." *The Journal of Legal Pluralism and Unofficial Law* 38 (52): 41–75.

Basu, Srimati. 2015. *The Trouble with Marriage: Feminists Confront Law and Violence in India*. Oakland, California: University of California Press.

Beaman, Lori, Raghabendra Chattopadhyay, Esther Duflo, Rohini Pande, and Petia Topalova. 2009. "Powerful Women: Does Exposure Reduce Bias?" *Quarterly Journal of Economics* 124 (4): 1497–1540.

Behl, Natasha. 2020. "Violence and Mentoring: Race, Gender, and Sexual Harassment." *PS: Political*

Science & Politics 53 (4): 780–783.

Belloni, Alexandre, Victor Chernozhukov, and Christian Hansen. 2014. "Inference on Treatment Effects after Selection among High-Dimensional Controls." *Review of Economic Studies* 81 (2): 608–650.

Bhanjdeo, Arundhita, Nivedita Narain, Surili Sheth, and Michael Walton. 2025. Seeing Like a State or Seeing the State? A Qualitative Study of a Government Program to Support Women's Self-Help Groups in Madhya Pradesh, India. Faculty Research Working Paper RWP25-002 Harvard Kennedy School.

Bhatt, Ela R. 2005*a*. *We Are Poor but So Many: The Story of Self-Employed Women in India*. Oxford University Press.

Bhatt, Ela R. 2005*b*. *We Are Poor but So Many: The Story of Self-Employed Women in India*. New Delhi: Oxford University Press.

Bhattacharya, Priyadarshini. 2024. ""Honor" Killings and Customary Laws: A Case Study of Khap Panchayats in Haryana, India." *Violence: An International Journal* 5 (1): 3–29.

Blair, Graeme, and Kosuke Imai. 2012. "Statistical Analysis of List Experiments." *Political Analysis* 20 (1): 47–77.

Blair, Graeme, and Nirvikar Jassal. 2022. "Accessing Justice for Survivors of Violence against Women." *Science* 377 (6602): 150–151.

Blair, Graeme, Kosuke Imai, and Jason Lyall. 2014. "Comparing and Combining List and Endorsement Experiments: Evidence from Afghanistan." *American Journal of Political Science* 58 (4): 1043–1063.

Blaydes, Lisa. 2023. "Assessing the Labor Conditions of Migrant Domestic Workers in the Arab Gulf States." *ILR Review* 76 (4): 724–747.

Bloch, Francis, and Vijayendra Rao. 2002. "Terror as a Bargaining Instrument: A Case Study of Dowry Violence in Rural India." *American Economic Review* 92 (4): 1029–1043.

Bobo, Lawrence, and Franklin D. Gilliam. 1990. "Race, Sociopolitical Participation, and Black Empowerment." *American Political Science Review* 84 (2): 377–393.

Bobonis, Gustavo J., Melissa González-Brenes, and Roberto Castro. 2013. "Public Transfers and Domestic Violence: The Roles of Private Information and Spousal Control." *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy* 5 (1): 179–205.

Brulé, Rachel E. 2020*a*. "Reform, Representation, and Resistance: The Politics of Property Rights' Enforcement." *The Journal of Politics* 82 (4): 1390–1405.

Brulé, Rachel E. 2020*b*. *Women, Power, and Property: The Paradox of Gender Equality Laws in India*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Brulé, Rachel E. 2023. "Women and Power in the Developing World." *Annual Review of Political Science* 26 (1): 33–54.

Calvi, Rossella, and Ajinkya Keskar. 2026. "'Til Dowry Do Us Part: Bargaining and Violence in Indian Families." *Review of Economics and Statistics* 108 (1): 129–144.

Chakravarti, Uma. 2008. "Beyond the Mantra of Empowerment: Time to Return to Poverty, Violence and Struggle." *IDS Bulletin* 39 (6): 1–16.

Chattopadhyay, Raghabendra, and Esther Duflo. 2004. "Women as Policy Makers: Evidence from a Randomized Policy Experiment in India." *Econometrica* 72 (5): 1409–1443.

Cheema, Ali, Ahsan Zia Farooqui, Sarah Khan, and Jacob N. Shapiro. 2023. "Canvassing the Gatekeepers: A Field Experiment to Increase Women Voters' Turnout in Pakistan." *American Political Science Review* 117 (1): 1–21.

Cheema, Ali, Ahsan Zia Farooqui, Sarah Khan, and Jacob N. Shapiro. 2026. "Putting Women's Concerns on the Agenda: Evidence from Community Policing in Pakistan.".

Chhibber, Pradeep. 2002. "Why are some women politically active? The household, public space, and political participation in India." *International Journal of Comparative Sociology* 43 (3–5): 409–429.

Chowdhry, Prem. 2004. "Caste Panchayats and the Policing of Marriage in Haryana: Enforcing

Kinship and Territorial Exogamy." *Contributions to Indian Sociology* 38 (1–2): 1–42.

Chowdhry, Prem. 2007. *Contentious Marriages, Eloping Couples: Gender, Caste, and Patriarchy in Northern India*. New Delhi: Oxford University Press.

Christie, Nils. 1986. "The Ideal Victim." In *From Crime Policy to Victim Policy: Reorienting the Justice System*, eds. Ezzat A. Fattah. Basingstoke: Macmillan 17–30.

Clark, Cindy J. 2012. "Survivors of Trafficking are Experts of their own Experiences." *The Lancet* 379 (9821): 1725.

Corbridge, Stuart, Glyn Williams, Manoj Srivastava, and Rene Veron. 2005. *Seeing the State: Governance and Governmentality in India*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Cronin-Furman, Kate, and Milli Lake. 2018. "Ethics Abroad: Fieldwork in Fragile and Violent Contexts." *PS: Political Science & Politics* 51 (3): 607–614.

Cruz, Cesi, and Charis Tolentino. 2019. "Gender, Social Recognition, and Political Influence.".

Daftary, Dolly. 2024. "Hindutva, OBCs, and Koli Selfhood in Western and Central India." *Critical Asian Studies* 56 (1): 72–88.

Dandona, Rakhi, Aradhita Gupta, Sibin George, Somy Kishan, and G. Anil Kumar. 2022. "Domestic Violence in Indian Women: Lessons from Nearly 20 Years of Surveillance." *BMC Women's Health* 22 (1): 128.

Datta, Upamanyu. 2015. "Socio-Economic Impacts of JEEViKA: A Large-Scale Self-Help Group Project in Bihar, India." *World Development* 68: 1–18.

Deshpande, Rajeshwari. 2024. "Shaping of the Woman Constituency in Indian Elections: Evidence from the NES Data." *Studies in Indian Politics* 12 (2): 303–317.

Devika, J., and Binitha V. Thampi. 2007. "Between 'Empowerment' and 'Liberation': The Kudumbashree Initiative in Kerala." *Indian Journal of Gender Studies* 14 (1): 33–59.

Díaz-Martín, Lucía, Akshara Gopalan, Eleonora Guarnieri, and Seema Jayachandran. 2023. "Greater than the Sum of the Parts? Evidence on Mechanisms Operating in Women's Groups." *The World Bank Research Observer* 38 (1): 1–35.

Dickson-Gomez, Julia, Maxine Wolfe, Mauricio Gaborit, and Gloria Bodnar. 2002. "Conducting Research in War-Ravaged Communities." *Human Organization* 61 (2): 131–143.

Dommaraju, Premchand. 2016. "Divorce and Separation in India." *Population and Development Review* 42 (2): 195–223.

Dotson, Kristie. 2011. "Tracking Epistemic Violence, Tracking Practices of Silencing." *Hypatia* 26 (2): 236–257.

Ellickson, Robert C. 1991. *Order Without Law: How Neighbors Settle Disputes*. Cambridge, Massachusetts: Harvard University Press.

Emerson, Robert M., Rachel I. Fretz, and Linda L. Shaw. 2011. *Writing Ethnographic Fieldnotes*. 2nd ed. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Evans, Peter. 1995. *Embedded Autonomy: States and Industrial Transformation*. Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press.

Feder, Gene, Roxane Agnew-Davies, Kathleen Baird, Danielle Dunne, Sandra Eldridge, Chris Griffiths, Alison Gregory, Annie Howell, Medina Johnson, Jean Ramsay, Clare Rutterford, and Debbie Sharp. 2011. "Identification and Referral to Improve Safety (IRIS) of Women Experiencing Domestic Violence with a Primary Care Training and Support Programme: A Cluster Randomised Controlled Trial." *The Lancet* 378 (9805): 1788–1795.

Fricker, Miranda. 2007. *Epistemic Injustice: Power and the Ethics of Knowing*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Fujii, Lee Ann. 2012. "Research Ethics 101: Dilemmas and Responsibilities." *PS: Political Science & Politics* 45 (4): 717–723.

Galanter, Marc. 1963. "Law and Caste in Modern India." *Asian Survey* 3 (11): 544–559.

Galanter, Marc. 1981. "Justice in Many Rooms: Courts, Private Ordering, and Indigenous Law." *The*

Journal of Legal Pluralism and Unofficial Law 13 (19): 1–47.

García-Moreno, Claudia, Kelsey Hegarty, Ana Flavia Lucas d'Oliveira, Jane Koziol-McLain, Manuela Colombini, and Gene Feder. 2015. "The Health-Systems Response to Violence against Women." *The Lancet* 385 (9977): 1567–1579.

Gibson, James L., and Amanda Gouws. 2026. "Toward Understanding Condonation of Gender-Based Violence: The Interaction of Patriarchal Values and Contextual Elements of Violence against Women." *The Journal of Politics* 88 (3).

Gottlieb, Jessica, Adrienne LeBas, and Janica Magat. 2025. "Taxation and Social Intermediaries: Experimental Evidence from Lagos, Nigeria." *British Journal of Political Science* 55: e99.

Govindrajan, Radhika. 2025. "'All Cases Are False': Law, Gendered Violence, and the Politics of Thickening in Himalayan India." *Journal of the Royal Anthropological Institute* 31 (1): 198–216.

Grimmer, Justin, and Brandon M. Stewart. 2013. "Text as Data: The Promise and Pitfalls of Automatic Content Analysis Methods for Political Texts." *Political Analysis* 21 (3): 267–297.

Hainmueller, Jens, Daniel J. Hopkins, and Teppei Yamamoto. 2014. "Causal Inference in Conjoint Analysis: Understanding Multidimensional Choices via Stated Preference Experiments." *Political Analysis* 22 (1): 1–30.

Heinze, Alyssa R. 2025. "Democratic Deepening or Elite Persistence? How Local Elites Adapt to Electoral Reform in Rural India." *American Political Science Review* 1–20.

Hidrobo, Melissa, Amber Peterman, and Lori Heise. 2016. "The Effect of Cash, Vouchers, and Food Transfers on Intimate Partner Violence: Evidence from a Randomized Experiment in Northern Ecuador." *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics* 8 (3): 284–303.

Hoffmann, Vivian, Vijayendra Rao, Vaishnavi Surendra, and Upamanyu Datta. 2021. "Relief from Usury: Impact of a Self-Help Group Lending Program in Rural India." *Journal of Development Economics* 148: 102567.

Holland, Alisha C. 2015. "The Distributive Politics of Enforcement." *American Journal of Political Science* 59 (2): 357–371.

Honig, Dan, Mekhala Krishnamurthy, and Rahul Karnamadakala Sharma. 2025. Relational State Capacity: Conceiving of Relationships as a Core Component of Society's Ability to Achieve Collective Ends. Working Paper 01 SNF Agora Institute, Johns Hopkins University.

Hossain, Mazeda, Cathy Zimmerman, Ligia Kiss, and Charlotte Watts. 2014. "Nowhere to Turn? Constraints on Women's Help-Seeking for Intimate Partner Violence." *PLOS ONE* 9 (11): e110511.

Htun, Mala, and S. Laurel Weldon. 2018. *The Logics of Gender Justice: State Action on Women's Rights Around the World*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

International Institute for Population Sciences (IIPS), and ICF. 2021. "National Family Health Survey (NFHS-5), 2019–21: India: Volume I.".

Iversen, Torben, and Frances Rosenbluth. 2006. "The Political Economy of Gender: Explaining Cross-National Variation in the Gender Division of Labor and the Gender Voting Gap." *American Journal of Political Science* 50 (1): 1–19.

Iyer, Lakshmi, Anandi Mani, Prachi Mishra, and Petia Topalova. 2012. "The Power of Political Voice: Women's Political Representation and Crime in India." *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics* 4 (4): 165–193.

Jandhyala, Kameshwari. 2001. "State Initiatives." *Seminar* (September).

Jassal, Nirvikar. 2020. "Gender, Law Enforcement, and Access to Justice: Evidence from All-Women Police Stations in India." *American Political Science Review* 114 (4): 1035–1054.

Jassal, Nirvikar. 2024. "Does Victim Gender Matter for Justice Delivery? Police and Judicial Responses to Women's Cases in India." *American Political Science Review* 118 (3): 1278–1304.

Jha, Prita. 2016. "Functioning of Protection Officers and the PWDVA 2005.".

Kabeer, Naila. 1994. *Reversed Realities: Gender Hierarchies in Development Thought*. London: Verso.

Kabeer, Naila. 1999. "Resources, Agency, Achievements: Reflections on the Measurement of Women's

Empowerment." *Development and Change* 30 (3): 435–464.

Kalpana, K. 2017. *Women, Microfinance and the State in Neo-liberal India*. New Delhi: Routledge.

Kandiyoti, Deniz. 1988. "Bargaining with Patriarchy." *Gender & Society* 2: 274–290.

Karnataka High Court. 2026. "*Abuzar Ahmed v. State of Karnataka*.".

Khan, Sarah. 2017. "What Women Want: Gender Gaps in Political Preferences." *CP: Newsletter of the Comparative Politics Organized Section of the American Political Science Association* .

Kitschelt, Herbert, and Steven I. Wilkinson, eds. 2007. *Patrons, Clients, and Policies: Patterns of Democratic Accountability and Political Competition*. Cambridge University Press.

Kowalski, Julia. 2023. *Counseling Women: Kinship Against Violence in India*. Philadelphia: University of Pennsylvania Press.

Krishna, Anirudh. 2002. *Active Social Capital: Tracing the Roots of Development and Democracy*. New York: Columbia University Press.

Kruks-Wisner, Gabrielle. 2018. *Claiming the State: Active Citizenship and Social Welfare in Rural India*. Cambridge University Press.

Kruks-Wisner, Gabrielle. 2022. "Social Brokerage: Accountability and the Social Life of Information." *Comparative Political Studies* 55 (14): 2382–2415.

Kruks-Wisner, Gabrielle, Akshay Mangla, and Sandip Sukhtankar. 2025. "Institutional Recognition: Activating Representation to Build Police Responsiveness to Women." *American Political Science Review* 1–19.

Kulkarni, Parashar. 2017. "Can Religious Norms Undermine Effective Property Rights? Evidence from Inheritance Rights of Widows in Colonial India." *British Journal of Political Science* 47 (3): 479–499.

Kumar, Ajay. 2012. "Khap Panchayats: A Socio-Historical Overview." *Economic & Political Weekly* .

Lake, Milli. 2018. *Strong NGOs and Weak States: Pursuing Gender Justice in the Democratic Republic of Congo and South Africa*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Lake, Milli, and Alexandra C. Hartman. 2025. "Institutions as Perpetrators: Power and Political Violence in Responses to Rape." *Perspectives on Politics* 1–22.

Lawyers Collective Women's Rights Initiative. 2012. Staying Alive: Fifth Monitoring and Evaluation Report on the Protection of Women from Domestic Violence Act, 2005. Technical report Lawyers Collective and International Center for Research on Women New Delhi: .

Lazarev, Egor. 2019. "Laws in Conflict: Legacies of War, Gender, and Legal Pluralism in Chechnya." *World Politics* 71 (4): 667–709.

Leithner, Monika, Michal Schuster, Sanna Caman, and Karin Lindqvist. 2021. "Barriers to Help-Seeking Among Female Victims of Partner Violence." *Journal of Family Violence* 36 (5): 583–593.

Lindsey, Summer. 2023. "Social Preferences: Measuring Private, Public and Group Preferences through Focus Groups." *Perspectives on Politics* 21 (4): 1178–1197.

Lowande, Kenneth, Melinda Ritchie, and Erinn Lauterbach. 2019. "Descriptive and Substantive Representation in Congress: Evidence from 80,000 Congressional Inquiries." *American Journal of Political Science* 63 (3): 644–659.

Lund, Christian. 2006. "Twilight Institutions: Public Authority and Local Politics in Africa." *Development and Change* 37 (4): 685–705.

Lust, Ellen. 2022. *Everyday Choices: The Role of Competing Authorities and Social Institutions in Politics and Development*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Macaulay, Stewart. 1963. "Non-Contractual Relations in Business: A Preliminary Study." *American Sociological Review* 28 (1): 55–67.

Mahoney, Martha R. 1991. "Legal Images of Battered Women: Redefining the Issue of Separation." *Michigan Law Review* 90 (1): 1–94.

Majumdar, Rochona. 2009. *Marriage and Modernity: Family Values in Colonial Bengal*. Durham, NC: Duke University Press.

Mangla, Akshay. 2022. "Social Conflict on the Front Lines of Reform: Institutional Activism and Girls' Education in Rural India." *Public Administration and Development* 42 (1): 95–105.

Manne, Kate. 2017. *Down Girl: The Logic of Misogyny*. New York: Oxford University Press.

Mansbridge, Jane, and Shauna L. Shames. 2008. "Toward a Theory of Backlash: Dynamic Resistance and the Central Role of Power." *Politics & Gender* 4 (4): 623–634.

Meier, Kenneth J., and Jill Nicholson-Crotty. 2006. "Gender, Representative Bureaucracy, and Law Enforcement: The Case of Sexual Assault." *Public Administration Review* 66 (6): 850–860.

Merry, Sally Engle. 1988. "Legal Pluralism." *Law & Society Review* 22 (5): 869–896.

Ministry of Home Affairs, Government of India. 2009. Advisory on Misuse of Section 498A of the Indian Penal Code. Technical report Ministry of Home Affairs New Delhi: .

Mnookin, Robert H., and Lewis Kornhauser. 1979. "Bargaining in the Shadow of the Law: The Case of Divorce." *Yale Law Journal* 88 (5): 950–997.

Murtazashvili, Jennifer Brick. 2016. *Informal Order and the State in Afghanistan*. New York: Cambridge University Press.

Nagaraj, Vasudha. 2010. "Local and Customary Forums: Adapting and Innovating Rules of Formal Law." *Indian Journal of Gender Studies* 17 (3): 429–450.

Nazneen, Sohela. 2023. "Women's Political Agency in Difficult Settings: Analysis of Evidence from Egypt, Nigeria, Mozambique, and Pakistan." *Development Policy Review* 41 (S1): e12685.

Newbigin, Eleanor. 2013. *The Hindu Family and the Emergence of Modern India: Law, Citizenship and Community*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Office of the Registrar General & Census Commissioner, India. 2011. "C-14: Population in Five Year Age Group by Residence and Sex, India – 2011.".

Palermo, Tia, Jennifer Bleck, and Amber Peterman. 2014. "Tip of the Iceberg: Reporting and Gender-Based Violence in Developing Countries." *American Journal of Epidemiology* 179 (5): 602–612.

Panda, Pradeep, and Bina Agarwal. 2005. "Marital Violence, Human Development and Women's Property Status in India." *World Development* 33 (5): 823–850.

Pande, Rohini. 2003. "Can Mandated Political Representation Increase Policy Influence for Disadvantaged Minorities? Theory and Evidence from India." *American Economic Review* 93 (4): 1132–1151.

Parreñas, Rhacel Salazar. 2022. *Unfree: Migrant Domestic Work in Arab States*. Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press.

Pateman, Carole. 1988. *The Sexual Contract*. Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press.

Pierotti, Rachael S., Milli Lake, and Chloé Lewis. 2018. "Equality on His Terms: Doing and Undoing Gender through Men's Discussion Groups." *Gender & Society* 32 (4): 540–562.

Prillaman, Soledad Artiz. 2023. "Strength in Numbers: How Women's Groups Close India's Political Gender Gap." *American Journal of Political Science* 67 (2): 390–410.

Prillaman, Soledad Artiz. 2024. *The Patriarchal Political Order: The Making and Unraveling of the Gendered Participation Gap in India*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Ramaswamy, Sheila et al. 2023. ""The Child Needs to Tell it to Me in Words": Barriers and Facilitators to Witness Competencies in Child Sexual Abuse Trials." *The International Journal of Children's Rights* 31 (2): 403–443.

Rosenblum, Daniel. 2015. "Unintended Consequences of Women's Inheritance Rights on Female Mortality in India." *Demography* 52 (4): 1117–1140.

Roy, Sanchari. 2015. "Empowering Women? Inheritance Rights, Female Education and Dowry Payments in India." *Journal of Development Economics* 114: 233–251.

Roychowdhury, Poulami. 2019. "Illicit Justice: Aspirational-Strategic Subjects and the Political Economy of Domestic Violence Law in India." *Law & Social Inquiry* 44 (2): 444–467.

Roychowdhury, Poulami. 2021*a*. *Capable Women, Incapable States: Negotiating Violence and Rights in India*. New York: Oxford University Press.

Roychowdhury, Poulami. 2021*b*. "Incorporation: Governing Gendered Violence in a State of Disem-

powerment." *American Journal of Sociology* 126 (4): 852–888.

Rudolph, Lukas. 2025. "Vignette Experiments Can Replicate Actual Behavioral Intent, but May Overstate Behavior: Panel Evidence on Environmental Migration from Bangladesh.".

Sabnis, Chetana. 2025. "The Price of Monogamy: Ideological Exclusion and the Recognition of Extramarital Relationships in India.".

Sanyal, Paromita. 2014. *Credit to Capabilities: A Sociological Study of Microcredit Groups in India*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Schwarz, Susanne, Matthew A. Baum, and Dara Kay Cohen. 2022. "(Sex) Crime and Punishment in the #MeToo Era: How the Public Views Rape." *Political Behavior* 44 (1): 75–104.

Sezgin, Yüksel. 2013. *Human Rights under State-Enforced Religious Family Laws in Israel, Egypt and India*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Shah, Ghanshyam. 2002. "The BJP and Backward Castes in Gujarat." In *Caste and Democratic Politics in India*, eds. Ghanshyam Shah. New Delhi: Permanent Black 295–314.

Sharma, Kanika, and Aashish Gupta. 2024. "Violence against Women in India: Levels and Trends of Incidence and Reporting." *Economic and Political Weekly* 59 (35): 1–10.

Solanki, Gopika. 2011. *Adjudication in Religious Family Laws: Cultural Accommodation, Legal Pluralism, and Gender Equality in India*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Srinivasan, Amia. 2021. *The Right to Sex: Feminism in the Twenty-First Century*. New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux.

Stokes, Susan C., Thad Dunning, Marcelo Nazareno, and Valeria Brusco. 2013. *Brokers, Voters, and Clientelism: The Puzzle of Distributive Politics*. Cambridge University Press.

Subramanian, Narendra. 2014. *Nation and Family: Personal Law, Cultural Pluralism, and Gendered Citizenship in India*. Stanford, CA: Stanford University Press.

Sukhtankar, Sandip, Gabrielle Kruks-Wisner, and Akshay Mangla. 2022. "Policing in Patriarchy: An Experimental Evaluation of Reforms to Improve Police Responsiveness to Women in India." *Science* 377 (6602): 191–198.

Suneetha, A., and Vasudha Nagaraj. 2006. "A Difficult Match: Women's Actions and Legal Institutions in the Face of Domestic Violence." *Economic and Political Weekly* 41(October): 4355–4362.

Supreme Court of India. 2014. "Arnesh Kumar v. State of Bihar.".

Thachil, Tariq. 2018. "Improving Surveys through Ethnography: Insights from India's Urban Periphery." *Studies in Comparative International Development* 53 (3): 281–299.

Tsai, Alexander C., Bernard Kakuhikire, Jessica M. Perkins, Dagmar Vořechovská, Amy Q. McDonough, Elizabeth L. Ogburn, Jordan M. Downey, and David R. Bangsberg. 2017. "Measuring Personal Beliefs and Perceived Norms about Intimate Partner Violence: Population-Based Survey Experiment in Rural Uganda." *PLOS Medicine* 14 (5): e1002303.

Vatuk, Sylvia. 2013. "The "Women's Court" in India: An Alternative Dispute Resolution Body for Women in Distress." *The Journal of Legal Pluralism and Unofficial Law* 45 (1): 76–103.

Waylen, Georgina. 2014. "Informal Institutions, Institutional Change, and Gender Equality." *Political Research Quarterly* 67 (1): 212–223.

Weaver, Vesla M., and Amy E. Lerman. 2010. "Political consequences of the carceral state." *American Political Science Review* 104 (4): 817–833.

Whiting, Susan H., and Xiao Ma. 2021. "Validating Vignette Designs with Real-World Data: A Study of Legal Mobilization in Response to Land Grievances in Rural China." *China Quarterly* 246: 586–601.

Wilfahrt, Martha, and Natalie Wenzell Letsa. 2023. "Judge, landlord, broker, watchman: assessing variation in chiefly duties and authority in the Ghana–Togo Borderlands." *The Journal of Modern African Studies* 61 (3): 439–462.

Winters, Matthew S., and Jeffrey Conroy-Krutz. 2021. "Preferences for Traditional and Formal Sector Justice Institutions to Address Land Disputes in Rural Mali." *World Development* 142: 105452.

Wood, Elisabeth Jean. 2006. "The Ethical Challenges of Field Research in Conflict Zones." *Qualitative Sociology* 29 (3): 373–386.

Woods, Sarah J., and Victoria L. Banyard. 2020. "Ethical Considerations in Research with Survivors of Intimate Partner Violence." *Journal of Interpersonal Violence* 35 (19–20): 3975–3996.

Yagnik, Achyut, and Suchitra Sheth. 2005. *The Shaping of Modern Gujarat: Plurality, Hindutva, and Beyond*. Penguin Books India.

You, Soosun. 2025. "The Main Squeeze: A Constricting Marriage Market Backlash Against Women's Empowerment.".

Appendix

The appendix is available upon request from the author.

surili.sheth@gess.ethz.ch